Political Violence and Bureaucratic Discretion: Evidence from German Asylum Decisions

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Abstract

Democratic accountability typically flows downward: voters pressure politicians, who direct agencies. I test whether policy also responds from below, through the discretionary decisions of the bureaucrats who implement it. I study German asylum decisions, exploiting arson attacks against refugee accommodations as salient signals of anti-immigrant hostility. Unlike the attacks by foreign or minority perpetrators studied previously, these attacks are committed by members of the majority population against a vulnerable minority, creating competing pressures on decision-makers: compliance with hostile demands versus empathy for victims. Using administrative data on 95,320 applicants (2015–2018), I find that immigration offices exposed to a nearby attack show a 0.6 percentage-point decline in the monthly approval probability (24 percent relative to the mean), under a uniform federal policy framework. Scaled to the full register, this implies on the order of 10,000 fewer approvals within applicants' first year. Survey evidence ties the decline to the interview month; suggestive evidence points to larger effects for attacks receiving more news coverage.

Keywords: Immigration, Political Violence, Asylum, Discrimination, Bureaucratic Discretion

JEL codes: D73, J15, K37

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1 Introduction

What if bureaucrats take the law into their own hands? Democratic accountability is typically understood as flowing downward: voters pressure politicians, who direct agencies. But policy implementation depends on the people who carry it out. Across courts, welfare offices, and government agencies, public servants exercise substantial discretion (Lipsky, 2010). When implementers possess such power, their decisions may respond not only to demands from policymakers but also to the social and political conditions of the local environment in which they operate. Policy may therefore be responsive to demands from the *bottom-up* through the individual's use of discretionary power beyond traditional *top-down* changes in directives by politicians.

To test whether signals of extreme and violent opposition to government policy affect its execution through public servants' use of bureaucratic discretion, I use the setting of German asylum decisions and the wave of political violence against refugees from 2015 to 2018. Throughout, I call an attack *majority-perpetrated* when it is committed by members of a country's majority population against members of a minority, and *minority-perpetrated* when it is attributed to members of a minority or to foreign perpetrators, as in the terrorist attacks studied in prior work. The distinction refers to who the perpetrators are relative to the society in which decision-makers operate, not to their motives. I show that majority-perpetrated arson attacks against refugee housing reduce asylum approval rates at nearby branch offices, and I present evidence that the effect operates through the discretion exercised in cases adjudicated with a personal interview.

The German asylum system is well-suited to study this question. First, asylum policy is determined at the federal level, so local variation in approval rates reflects adjudication rather than policy change. Second, applicants are quasi-randomly allocated across Germany through a centralized distribution system, limiting sorting. Third, geographic separation between applicants' residences and the 48 branch offices that process their claims allows me to separate office-side exposure to local hostility from exposure near applicants' own residences.[1] Majority-perpetrated arson attacks against refugee accommodations serve as salient, localized signals of extreme and violent opposition to existing government policy.

I find consistent evidence across three independent data sources that arson attacks against refugee accommodations reduce asylum approval rates. The main analysis uses individual-level administrative data from the Central Register of Foreigners (95,320 applicants, 2015–2018) and shows that immigration offices exposed to a nearby attack exhibit a 0.6 percentage-point decline in the monthly approval probability (24 percent relative to

[1] Of the 48 branch offices, 43 enter the estimation sample (27 treated, 16 never-treated; Appendix Table A.4). The others, among them the Nuremberg headquarters, the Berlin arrival center, the Bonn branch, and the Frankfurt Airport transit office, are removed by the regular-application filter (Appendix Table A.3).

the mean). The estimate implies roughly 2,000 fewer first-year approvals in the estimation sample, or on the order of 10,000 among all applicants once the 20 percent research sample is scaled up to the register. The decline builds over several months after an attack, consistent with the lag between interview and decision, and it survives absorbing month-by-month shocks to applicants' residence counties.

The remaining evidence corroborates the decline and locates it in the interview. A within-office test comparing cases decided via written procedure to those adjudicated with a personal interview at the same office suggests that the decline is concentrated among interview cases. A second, independently collected dataset of office-level aggregate statistics on first-instance decisions corroborates the decline and shows that attacks shifted the content of decisions rather than their timing or volume. A third test uses individual-level survey data from the IAB-BAMF-SOEP refugee survey. The decline in approval probability replicates and is concentrated among applicants exposed in their interview month rather than their decision month. These results indicate that the interview is the moment where officer discretion is highest and where local conditions influence decision-making. Results are consistent with a *bottom-up* channel in which approval rates move in the direction favored by the perpetrators of the violence.

In the refugee survey, the decline is larger for attacks receiving substantial media coverage, consistent with an information channel identified in previous research (Emeriau, 2024; Spirig, 2023). Survey evidence from the SOEP suggests that arson attacks shift public attitudes among residents of immigration office counties. Concerns about immigration rise persistently, paralleling the durable voting shifts documented in Sabet et al. (2023). Concerns about xenophobic hostility spike in the immediate aftermath but dissipate within weeks, making any resistive responses short-lived, consistent with previous results (Freitas-Monteiro and Prömel, 2024). The asymmetry suggests a bureaucratic response that tilts toward stricter treatment, although the SOEP measures residents' attitudes rather than those of officers.

A large body of literature documents how political violence reshapes political outcomes, tracing effects predominantly through the electoral channel. Terrorist attacks shift voting toward nationalist parties (Gould and Klor, 2010; Aidt and Franck, 2015; Rees and Smith, 2022; Gassebner et al., 2008), and far-right violence increases support for far-right parties and hardens anti-immigration attitudes (Sabet et al., 2023; Jomni and Zakharov, 2026), though not universally (Larsen et al., 2020). In each case, violence enters the policy process by changing how citizens vote, which pressures politicians to adjust.

Bureaucratic discretion shapes outcomes across government: in courts (Shayo and Zussman, 2011; Arnold et al., 2018; Eren and Mocan, 2018; Dobbie et al., 2018), policing (Grosjean et al., 2023), welfare allocation (Hemker and Rink, 2017; Maestas et al., 2013; Bolhaar et al., 2020), and immigration (Emeriau, 2023, 2024; Chen et al., 2016; Gun-

dacker et al., 2025). External events influence how that discretion is exercised (Gould and Klor, 2016; Chen and Loecher, 2025; Heyes and Saberian, 2019; Danziger et al., 2011). In the literature closest to this paper, Shayo and Zussman (2011) show that Israeli judges exhibit heightened in-group bias after terrorist attacks, and Brodeur and Wright (2019) find that 9/11 reduced asylum approval rates for Muslim applicants in the United States. Both are cases of minority-perpetrated attacks, where stricter treatment admits a rational-threat-updating interpretation. Emeriau (2024) shows that news of Mediterranean shipwrecks raised asylum approval rates in France, demonstrating that empathy can push in the opposite direction. The most closely related studies are Spirig (2023), who shows that media coverage of immigration reduces judicial approval rates in Switzerland, and Gundacker et al. (2025), who find lower approval probabilities for refugees in immigration-averse regions of Germany. Neither examines whether political violence directly shapes bureaucratic decisions.

This paper makes two contributions. First, rather than tracing responses to majority-perpetrated violence through the ballot box, I examine whether it alters policy implementation directly, through the discretionary decisions of the public servants who carry it out. Compared to other studies of violent events and adjudication (Emeriau, 2024; Brodeur and Wright, 2019; Shayo and Zussman, 2011), I provide evidence on a qualitatively distinct hostility signal: violence committed by members of the majority. Unlike minority-perpetrated attacks, the predicted direction of the bureaucratic response is ambiguous. Such violence could normalize hostility (Bursztyn et al., 2020; Sabet et al., 2023) and serve as a signal of extreme opposition to current policy, demanding stricter bureaucratic treatment. Violent or extremist acts may also discredit political positions (Bursztyn et al., 2020; Chenoweth and Stephan, 2011; Feinberg et al., 2020; Freitas-Monteiro and Prömel, 2024) and create empathy for the targeted group. Existing work on minority-perpetrated violence that results in stricter treatment can be interpreted through rational decision-making given updated threat perceptions. Majority-perpetrated violence against a vulnerable minority offers no such mechanism, as the targeted group poses no greater threat after the attack. Instead, it generates competing pressures on decision-makers: compliance with hostile demands versus empathy-driven leniency. I show that the former wins out.

Second, I provide the first analysis of asylum adjudication using individual-level administrative data from Germany, the largest recipient of asylum applications in Europe. Between 2015 and 2018, Germany received approximately 1.5 million first-time applications, accounting for 40 percent of all applications filed across Europe. Previous studies using administrative data have focused on countries with substantially smaller caseloads such as France (9 percent) (Emeriau, 2024) and Switzerland (3 percent) (Spirig, 2023).

Section 2 describes the German asylum system. Section 3 develops the conceptual framework. Section 4 presents the data, Section 5 the empirical strategy, and Section 6 the

results. Section 7 discusses threats to identification, Section 8 examines mechanisms and heterogeneity, and Section 9 discusses limitations. Section 10 concludes.

2 Institutional Setting

2.1 Allocation System

Germany administers refugee arrivals through a centralized allocation system. Upon arrival, asylum seekers register at reception centers and are allocated to federal states via the EASY system (*Erstverteilung der Asylbegehrenden*), which follows the Königsteiner Schlüssel, a formula weighted by each state's population and tax revenue. States then distribute individuals to municipalities based on housing availability. Allocation decisions are largely independent of individual refugee characteristics (Jaschke et al., 2022; Aksoy et al., 2023).

Following municipal assignment, applicants are directed to one of 48 branch offices for processing, often located in different counties than applicants' residences. This geographic wedge is what allows me to separate office-side exposure from applicant-side exposure: an arson attack near an immigration office reaches that office's staff and local environment. Given that applicants in the same location may be assigned to different offices, confounding effects on applicant behavior can be controlled for.

The network of branch offices expanded rapidly in 2015–2016 and was consolidated mainly after the sample period: the number of sites in the immigration office's public site list falls from 64 in 2017 to 44 in 2021.[2] An office enters the estimation sample only in months in which the CRF records it processing applications, and office × sub-experiment fixed effects absorb level differences across offices.

2.2 Decision Process

Applicants generally undergo a personal interview conducted by an asylum officer (temporary exceptions for simplified written procedures are discussed in Section 8.1). The interview forms the basis for assessing eligibility for protection. Officers have substantial discretion: they control the line of questioning, assess the credibility of testimony, and shape the record on which the decision what protection to grant is based. In 2016, to clear the backlog, the immigration office temporarily allowed the officer who conducts the interview and the officer who signs the decision to differ; internal guidelines continued to require that they be the same person in principle, and the office keeps no statistics on how often they differed.[3] The interview record nonetheless remains the main evidentiary basis

[2] Staff headcount by site, released in response to a freedom-of-information request on FragDenStaat. The list is available from 2017 onward.

[3] Answer of the federal government to a parliamentary inquiry, BT-Drs. 19/6786, answer to question 32.

for the decision, so judgments formed at the interview carry into the outcome whether or not the interviewer also decides.

Applicants may receive one of several outcomes: full refugee status under the Geneva Convention (three-year permit, immediate family reunification), subsidiary protection (one-year permit, restricted reunification), a deportation ban, or rejection. Rejected applicants may appeal to administrative courts. See Appendix Table A.1 for detailed descriptions of protection levels. Figure 2 illustrates the observability of each outcome type under the 12-month restriction used in the empirical design.

The interview serves as the primary opportunity for decision-makers to assess the credibility and substance of an asylum claim. During this meeting, officers evaluate the applicant's testimony, probe for inconsistencies, and form judgments about protection eligibility. While applications are filed and administrative processing occurs over extended periods, the interview represents a key moment of subjective evaluation. Events occurring close to this critical decision point are therefore most likely to influence officer judgments, whether through heightened threat perceptions following local violence or through increased empathy following humanitarian tragedies. Following Emeriau (2024), who uses interview dates to identify the timing of discretionary effects on asylum decisions in France, I treat the interview as the critical moment for adjudication.

The degree of discretion varies by applicant origin. During 2016–2018, Syrian applicants were rarely rejected outright, though officers exercised discretion over whether to grant full refugee status or the less favorable subsidiary protection.[4] For applicants from other origins, officer discretion extends to the binary approval decision as well. This variation in the scope of discretion generates a testable prediction: if attacks operate through officer discretion at the interview, effects should concentrate among nationalities where officers have more latitude over outcomes.

The scope for discretion was particularly wide at the start of the study period due to weak internal oversight. The immigration office's central quality-assurance unit reviewed approximately 1% of decisions in 2015, and the dual-review requirement for individual decisions was made formally binding by central directive only in September 2017 (see Appendix A for details). Until at least late 2017, officers operated with minimal systematic review of their individual decisions.

3 Conceptual Framework

I conceptualize arson attacks against refugee accommodations as salient events that increase the local visibility of anti-immigrant sentiment and social dissatisfaction. Such

[4] In 2016, 167 of 266,866 Syrian applications were rejected outright; of the remainder, 165,754 received full Geneva-Convention protection and the rest received subsidiary protection, which restricts family reunification.

attacks signal that segments of the population hold strong anti-refugee views, intense enough to motivate violent action. The existing literature on how salient events affect bureaucratic and judicial decision-makers suggests several pathways through which such attacks may alter officer behavior. The predicted direction is ambiguous ex ante, as the same event can produce both compliance with and resistance to political violence.

Shift in own beliefs. Arson attacks signal that social cohesion in the local community is under strain. Officers who learn of violence against refugee accommodations may perceive their surroundings as destabilized. This perceived disruption can harden attitudes toward the group associated with the tension, even when that group is itself the target. Sabet et al. (2023) show that successful right-wing attacks in Germany shift individual attitudes rightward and increase anti-immigration concern, even among previously unaffiliated individuals. Salient events do not need to change beliefs from nothing but can instead activate predispositions that already exist. Grosjean et al. (2023) show that Trump campaign rallies increased racial bias in policing, with effects concentrated among officers whose baseline behavior was already more biased. In the immigration office context, rapid hiring during 2015–2016 brought officers with heterogeneous predispositions into the same offices. An arson attack nearby may both shift attitudes on the margin and activate restrictive tendencies among officers already predisposed. These are two sides of the same process, requiring neither strategic calculation nor conscious awareness.

Shift in perceived expectations. A distinct but complementary channel operates through perceived expectations rather than personal beliefs. Attacks may not change what officers think about refugees, but instead what officers believe their environment expects of them. Spirig (2023) shows that higher asylum salience in Swiss media leads to more restrictive judicial decisions on asylum appeals and is not restricted to judges of any particular ideology. Officers may calibrate decisions toward what they perceive as the locally appropriate position, whether through internalized salience effects or through social pressure from colleagues and the community atmosphere (Lipsky, 2010). This channel does not require officers to personally hold anti-refugee views. The institutional context of 2016–2017 amplifies this pathway: the immigration office was rapidly expanding its workforce, and new hires on probationary periods may have been especially susceptible to signals about local expectations. Emeriau (2023) shows that new hires are often more biased than experienced ones.

Protective action. Arson attacks physically endanger refugees in their accommodations. Given that positive asylum decisions allow refugees to choose their place of residence more freely, officers confronted with physical endangerment may view applicants more favorably. Emeriau (2024) shows that news of Mediterranean shipwrecks increased asylum approval rates in France by 4.4 percentage points when featured on prime-time

television. However, this response was short-lived: it appeared the day after the event and was no longer detectable two days later. Given that arson attacks occur within a context of social tension rather than humanitarian disaster, it is unclear whether they trigger the same victim framing.

Backlash against extremism. A broader literature on responses to political violence shows that extreme tactics frequently activate moral outrage and sympathy for targets (Wasow, 2020; Feinberg et al., 2020; Chenoweth and Stephan, 2011). In the German context, Freitas-Monteiro and Prömel (2024) document how far-right demonstrations increase concern about hostility toward foreigners, raise intentions to donate to refugee aid, and benefit left-wing parties. Officers may feel revulsion toward the attackers and compensate by exercising discretion more favorably.

The framework does not provide a clear prediction for the sign of the net effect. The resistance pathways require specific conditions, such as victim framing and immediate temporal proximity, that may not hold for arson attacks in this context. Attack severity provides one dimension of leverage: if empathy or backlash operates, aggravated arson that endangers human life should show a different pattern than minor property damage. Whether attacks receive media coverage may matter for the salience channel. I return to the severity distinction in the heterogeneity results (Section 8.4) and to the media-coverage channel in the survey-based analysis (Section 8.2).

4 Data and Measurement

This section describes the data infrastructure used to analyze how localized political violence impacts asylum adjudication: official administrative records on anti-refugee violence compiled from parliamentary interpellations, individual-level longitudinal administrative tracking data from the Central Register of Foreigners, individual-level survey data from the IAB-BAMF-SOEP Survey of Refugees, office-level aggregate decision statistics, and news coverage data from LexisNexis.

4.1 Attack data

A key source of administrative data on anti-refugee violence comes from parliamentary interpellations submitted to the German federal government. These interpellations are formal inquiries that require the government to provide detailed information on specific topics, in this case regarding attacks on refugee accommodations and asylum seekers.

The federal government compiles responses using data from the Federal Criminal Police Office through the Criminal Police Reporting Service for Politically Motivated Crime. These reports provide incident-level data on attacks on asylum accommodations (both occupied facilities and those under construction), attacks on asylum seekers in public

spaces, and far-right protests at or near refugee facilities. Each incident is recorded with the date, location (city and state), and the specific criminal offense.

I use quarterly interpellations covering 2015–2021, which provide the most systematic and comprehensive administrative record of anti-refugee violence during this period. The timing of each office's first nearby attack is determined from attacks during the sample period, 2015–2018. Offices with no nearby attack during this period are classified as never-treated. Figure 1 pools all attacks over 2015–2018 and shows the branch offices in the estimation sample together with their 25 km treatment radius. Of the 245 recorded arson attacks, 70 occurred within 25 km of one of these offices. Every treated office has at least one attack within its radius, while none of the never-treated offices does. Attacks are most frequent in North Rhine-Westphalia (54) and Saxony (41) and decline sharply after 2016 (105 in 2015, 107 in 2016, 28 in 2017, and 5 in 2018), so most offices are first treated in 2015 or early 2016. Six of the 16 never-treated offices are in Bavaria. Appendix Figure A.1 repeats the map separately for each year and marks when each office is first treated.

The data have two advantages over media-based compilations. First, they are based on official police reports rather than media coverage, which reduces concerns about selective reporting. Second, they provide standardized legal classifications of offenses, enabling consistent severity coding across incidents and years.

The data classify arson incidents according to the German Criminal Code. I distinguish between simple arson and aggravated arson, where the latter involves endangering human life, occupied buildings, or serious bodily harm.[5] I construct an *aggravated arson* indicator for attacks classified under the aggravated categories, representing offenses with higher potential risk to human life. This distinction allows me to examine whether the severity of attacks moderates their effect on asylum decisions.

4.2 Application data

My main data source is the Central Register of Foreigners (CRF), a nationwide administrative register that is centrally managed by a federal office. It contains personal data, nationality, residency status, and other legal matters such as asylum applications, for all non-German citizens residing in or having resided in the country. The immigration office provides the AZR Research Dataset 2023, a 20% random sample drawn from the CRF on 31 December 2023 (Gleiser and Salas Escobar, 2024).

The data contain information on place of residence, residence status, and other personal characteristics, with records entered by local municipalities, immigration offices, the police, and other authorities. For refugees, the residence-status history tracks the progression of the asylum application. Socio-demographic variables include age, gender, country of

[5] See Appendix Table A.2 for the full classification of criminal offenses.

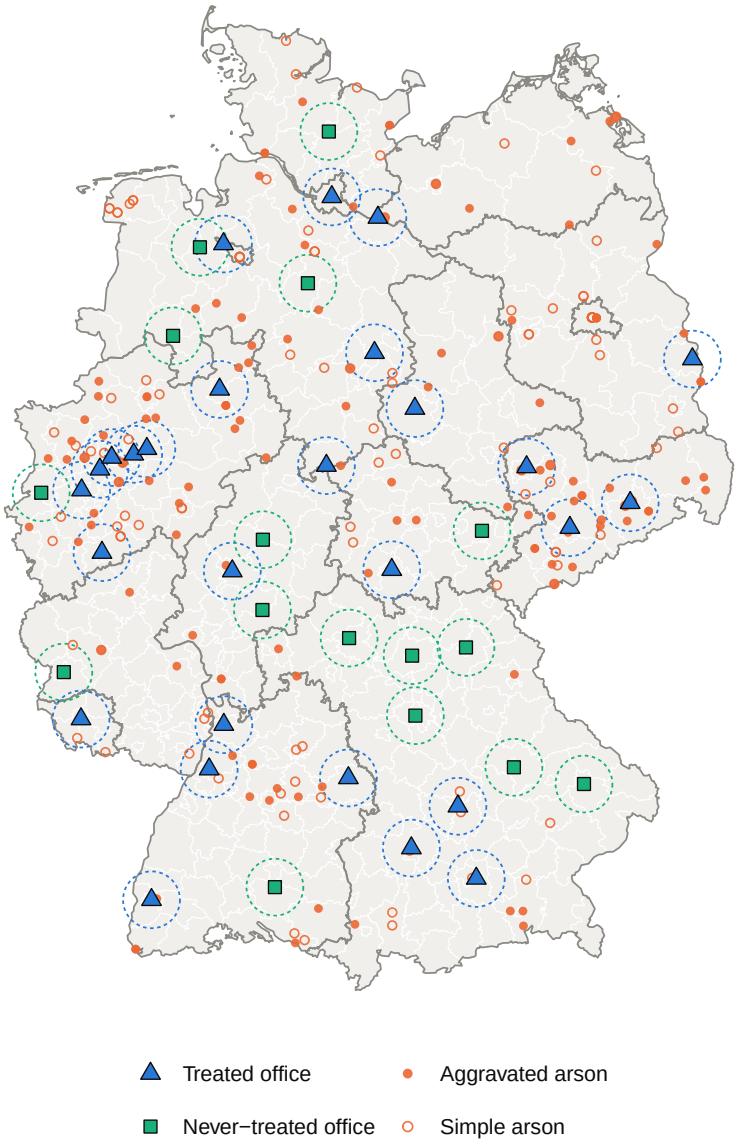


Figure 1: Arson Attacks and Branch Offices, 2015–2018 (Pooled)

Notes: Orange markers show the 245 arson attacks on refugee accommodations recorded in the parliamentary interpellations for 2015–2018, pooled over all years (filled: aggravated arson; open: simple arson). Triangles mark the 27 treated and squares the 16 never-treated branch offices in the estimation sample; dashed circles show the 25 km radius that defines treatment. Thin lines are county boundaries and thick lines state boundaries. Attack locations are geocoded from the interpellations and office locations from the register of authority codes. Boundaries: © GeoBasis-DE/BKG (2022).

origin, education, and previous employment. Coverage is limited to non-citizens at the time of sample draw, since foreigners who naturalize are deleted from the CRF upon obtaining German citizenship. Section 7 discusses whether selective sample attrition threatens identification.

The estimation sample covers person-month observations in calendar years 2015–2018. I remove applicants eligible for the expedited written procedure, in which decisions were rendered on the basis of a written questionnaire without a personal interview. Under this policy, Syrian, Iraqi, and Eritrean nationals who entered Germany before 1 Jan-

uary 2016 and filed their application before 17 March 2016 were eligible for a fast-track procedure that bypassed the interview stage.[6] Excluding these cases restricts the sample to applicants whose claims were adjudicated through the regular procedure with a personal interview, where officer discretion is exercised. Section 8.1 tests this mechanism by comparing decisions reached via personal interview to those decided through written procedure at the same office; the decline is concentrated among interview cases.

The resulting sample restrictions produce 95,945 eligible applicants across 43 offices (Table A.3). This constructed sample is distinct from the specification-specific estimation samples: the preferred never-treated regression uses 95,320 applicants, the not-yet-treated regression uses 61,722, and the shorter-duration regressions with pooled comparison groups use 95,938. Each regression table reports distinct applicants in that specification's estimation sample.

Treatment timing is computed from attacks during 2015–2018. Appendix Table A.4 lists each of the 43 branch offices in the sample, its treatment status, and first attack month. Table 1 reports nationality shares and cumulative acceptance rates for the 95,937 applicants in disclosed nationality-by-application-year cells; the difference from 95,945 reflects disclosure suppression, not a further estimation restriction. Syria and Eritrea together account for roughly 20% of the sample and are resolved quickly (over 75% of positive decisions within 12 months), while Afghanistan and Iran have substantially lower and slower acceptance rates. Appendix Figure A.2 plots the discrete hazard rate and cumulative incidence of positive and negative decisions over the first 23 months after application.

One key limitation of the CRF data is that it only contains legally binding changes to the asylum status. Therefore, asylum status is only observed once the legal appeals process has been exhausted (see Figure 2). Interview dates, initial decisions, and their timing therefore cannot be directly inferred from the data, so the treatment-relevant window cannot be precisely identified. However, the duration between application and final status provides information on the initial decision and motivates the use of a duration model. The next section describes how these features are leveraged.

4.3 Additional data

Survey data. I complement the administrative data with survey data from the IAB-BAMF-SOEP Survey of Refugees, a longitudinal survey of refugees, asylum seekers, and their household members in Germany (Brücker et al., 2016). The survey is conducted

[6]From autumn 2014, the immigration office decided most applications by Syrian nationals, and by Eritrean and certain Iraqi applicants, in a written procedure on the basis of a questionnaire, without a personal interview. Decrees of the Federal Ministry of the Interior restored the personal interview for applicants entering on or after 1 January 2016 and for all applications filed on or after 17 March 2016; written decisions on earlier cases continued into mid-2016 (BT-Drs. 18/9992, answers to questions 1 and 8). Because the CRF does not identify religious minorities, the exclusion applies the rule to all Iraqi applicants and therefore also removes some Iraqi cases decided after an interview. See Section 8.1.

Table 1: Acceptance Rates by Nationality and Decision Horizon

Nationality	N	Share (%)	⩽3m (%)	⩽6m (%)	⩽12m (%)	⩽24m (%)	Ever (%)
Other	44,856	46.8	1.9	4.0	7.0	10.2	13.8
Syria	16,821	17.5	26.4	51.6	75.5	88.3	93.8
Afghanistan	16,098	16.8	2.2	8.2	21.2	35.5	54.6
Iraq	8,559	8.9	11.0	26.8	49.0	55.0	59.2
Iran	4,086	4.3	2.9	9.8	27.6	44.5	59.8
Nigeria	2,393	2.5	0.0	0.5	3.4	7.3	12.5
Eritrea	2,103	2.2	23.9	42.2	64.4	76.7	81.3
Turkey	1,021	1.1	1.9	8.6	17.1	22.2	32.8
Total	95,937	100.0	7.5	16.1	27.3	35.1	42.3

Notes: Cumulative acceptance rates by nationality, pooled over application years 2015–2018. The constructed sample contains 95,945 unique applicants; the disclosed nationality-by-year counts sum to 95,937. Cells whose applicant counts are suppressed or unreported are omitted from both counts and outcome totals. Shares use the disclosed total of 95,937, and acceptance rates use the disclosed applicant count for each nationality. Additional outcome counts below five are suppressed even where applicant counts are disclosed; omitting these outcome counts from the numerator can slightly understate acceptance rates. Rates are cumulative: ⩽6m includes positive decisions within six months of application, not only those between three and six months. "Ever" denotes acceptance regardless of duration. Source: AZR Research Dataset 2023.

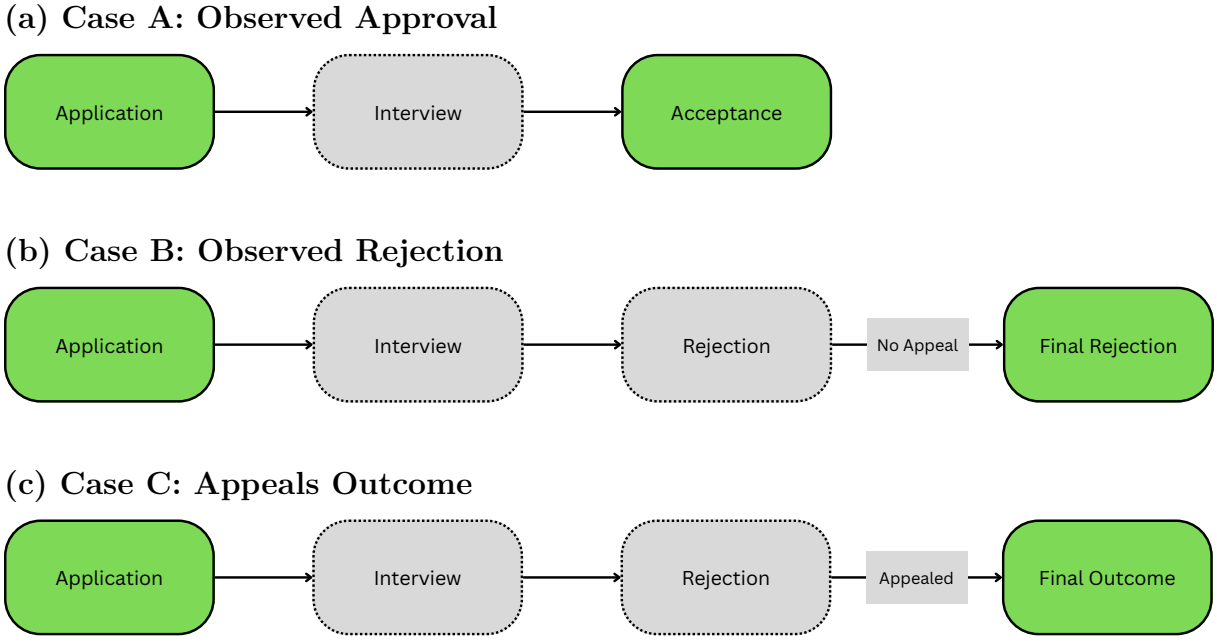


Figure 2: Data Observability in Asylum Decision Processes

Notes: Schematic illustration of three types of asylum application outcomes and their observability under the 12-month restriction. Green shading indicates stages observed in the data; grey shading indicates stages that are unobserved. Case A: positive decision within 12 months (observed). Case B: negative decision within 12 months (observed as zero in outcome variable). Case C: appeal process extending beyond 12 months (applicant exits sample as censored). The 12-month window is designed to capture first-instance determinations while excluding most appeals.

jointly by the Institute for Employment Research (IAB), the Research Centre of the Federal Office for Migration and Refugees (BAMF-FZ), and the Socio-Economic Panel (SOEP) at DIW Berlin. Its sampling frame is the CRF, also used in the main analysis.

The survey is restricted to nationalities classified as having a good prospect of approval at the time of sampling, and oversampling was applied to women and persons aged over 30.

For analysis of mechanisms I use the German Socio-Economic Panel (SOEP) to investigate changes in beliefs at the site of arson attacks. The SOEP is a nationally representative longitudinal household survey that has interviewed approximately 15,000 households and 30,000 individuals annually since 1984 (Goebel et al., 2019). The survey contains detailed information on demographics, socioeconomic status, and migration background, as well as attitudes toward immigration and perceived threats. Geocoded identifiers at the county level allow me to match respondents to immigration office counties. I use SOEP v41 (survey years 2015–2019) for the public attitudes analysis in Section 8.3.

Office-level aggregate statistics. I complement the individual-level CRF data with office-level aggregate statistics on first-instance asylum decisions, originally compiled by Barreto et al. (2022). These data record the total number of decisions and their outcomes for each immigration office branch, nationality, and year cell, covering the period 2010–2020. The office-level analysis covers 52 offices, including offices unavailable in the CRF data; this differs from the 48 offices in the CRF office frame and the 43 retained in the individual-level estimation sample. Because the statistics tabulate first-instance decisions only and exclude appeals, they allow a direct test of whether arson attacks altered the content of initial decisions rather than the downstream appeal process. The aggregation, however, means that applicant-level covariates are unavailable and applicant behavior cannot be separated from officer behavior, so I use these data as a robustness check rather than as a primary specification (Section 6.1.1).

News data. To measure the media salience of arson attacks, I use raw LexisNexis article data originally collected by Graeber et al. (2026) to retrieve full-text news articles from major German newspapers, applying keyword filters for refugee shelter and arson terms. Articles are matched to attacks using a spatial window of 25 km and a temporal window of ± 7 days from the attack date, with manually verified overrides for attacks where geographic identifiers in the press coverage are imprecise. The resulting article count serves as the salience measure in the survey-based analysis of news amplification (Section 8.2).

5 Empirical Strategy

5.1 Identification Strategy

The CRF records only the final legally binding asylum status, observed after any appeals have concluded. Approved applications resolve at the time of the first-instance decision, but rejected applications may be appealed and appear in the data only much later. Using

the date of the final outcome to define pre- and post-treatment periods would therefore conflate the *content* of decisions with their *timing*: a post-attack decline in observed positive outcomes could reflect either fewer approvals or a shift in when cases resolve.

To separate these two channels, I define the outcome as the monthly approval indicator

$$Y_{it} = \mathbf{1}(\text{applicant } i \text{ receives a positive decision in month } t) \tag{1}$$

with $Y_{it} = 0$ for all months if no approval is recorded within 12 months of application, regardless of whether the applicant was rejected, is still pending, or has entered the appeals process. This creates a person × month panel in which each applicant contributes observations from the month of application until either a positive decision or the 12-month censoring point.

Because approvals are not appealed, any first-instance approval is observed at its true decision date, even though rejections are not directly observed at the correct time. Among still-pending applicants, the expected approval indicator decomposes as:

$$\mathbb{E}[Y_{it}] = \mathbb{E}\big[\underbrace{\lambda_{it}}_{\substack{\text{decision}\\\text{rendering}}} \cdot \underbrace{Z_i}_{\substack{\text{approval}\\\text{outcome}}}\big] \tag{2}$$

where λ_{it} is the probability that a first-instance decision of any kind is rendered for applicant i in month t among still-pending applicants, and $Z_i \in \{0, 1\}$ indicates whether the decision is positive. The treatment effect of interest is the change in $\mathbb{E}[Z_i]$. Recovering this from the observed left-hand side requires assumptions that discipline λ_{it} and the composition of the at-risk population. The design rests on three assumptions.

Assumption ID.1 (Exogenous applicant composition). Conditional on place of residence, the allocation of asylum applicants across processing branch offices is orthogonal to treatment status. For applications submitted prior to treatment, office assignment is predetermined and plausibly uncorrelated with treatment. For applications submitted after treatment, I assume that the flow of new filings to each office does not respond to nearby arson attacks. This is plausible because applicants are assigned to offices administratively and cannot choose their processing location. Figure B.1 tests this assumption by showing that predicted approval rates, constructed from pre-treatment cell means, do not shift around treatment timing.

Assumption ID.2 (Appeals fall outside the observation window). The combined first-instance processing time and appeals duration exceeds the 12-month observation window, so the only positive outcomes observed within that window are first-instance approvals: no successful appeal contaminates Y_{it}. This is empirically supported by institutional processing times: average asylum court proceedings took 12.5 months in 2018, on top of several months of first-instance immigration office processing.[7]

[7]Source: parliamentary interpellations on asylum processing durations (Schwerpunktfragen zur

Assumption ID.3 (Content, not timing). Exposure to a nearby arson attack shifts the expected approval outcome $\mathbb{E}[Z_i]$ but not the decision-rendering hazard λ_{it}. Let D indicate whether a branch office has been exposed to a nearby arson attack. ID.3 requires that, within calendar month × duration × nationality cells:

$$\mathbb{E}[\lambda \mid D = 1] = \mathbb{E}[\lambda \mid D = 0] \tag{3}$$

so that λ_{it} is mean-independent of treatment status and any difference in $\mathbb{E}[Y_{it}]$ across treatment arms isolates the shift in $\mathbb{E}[Z_i]$, not in the timing of decisions. I test this assumption directly using office-level aggregate statistics in Section 6.1.1 and find no evidence that the decision-rendering hazard changed at treated offices.

Estimand. Under Assumptions ID.1–ID.3, the difference-in-differences coefficient identifies:

$$\beta = \mathbb{E}[\lambda] \cdot \big(\mathbb{E}[Z \mid D = 1] - \mathbb{E}[Z \mid D = 0]\big) \tag{4}$$

the shift in the approval content of decisions at exposed offices, scaled by the average decision-rendering hazard $\mathbb{E}[\lambda]$. The factorization from Equation 2 to 4 requires that λ_{it} and Z_i are conditionally independent given treatment status and cell membership: ID.3 ensures λ_{it} does not vary with D, and ID.1 ensures the composition of Z_i does not vary with D within cells, so the expectation of their product separates. β therefore isolates the change in approval rates for treated applications.

Treatment coding. A branch office enters the post-first-attack regime upon the first arson attack occurring within a 25 km radius. Subsequent attacks during the sample period are not coded separately, so the post-period coefficients reflect the joint effect of the first attack and any subsequent nearby incidents at the same office. This simplifies the event-study to a single cutoff per office but means the design does not, by itself, decompose the initial shock from cumulative exposure.

From office-level estimate to officer discretion. The office-level estimate could reflect three channels beyond individual caseworker discretion: differential managerial directives at treated offices, differential staffing or case-assignment responses, or applicant-side confounders operating within the office's local ecosystem. Because asylum law is federal and immigration office headquarters issues centralized operational guidelines that apply identically to all 48 branch offices, responses that differentially affect offices such as increased oversight would have to be made explicit. The direct channel through which local conditions can enter adjudication is the individual officer's exercise of discretion, in

Asylverfahrensdauer, BT-Drs. 20/5709).

assessing credibility, weighing evidence, and determining protection outcomes. Section 7 provides an extended discussion of institutional responses and other threats.

Threats to identification. I discuss threats to this design in Section 7, after presenting the main results.

5.2 Estimation Strategy

I estimate two complementary specifications on a person × month panel: a collapsed difference-in-differences and a dynamic event study. Each is implemented using both a heterogeneity-robust stacking estimator (preferred) following Baker et al. (2022) and a conventional TWFE specification (benchmark). The outcome Y_{irdt} is a binary indicator equal to one if applicant i, residing in county r and processed by branch office d, receives a positive first-instance decision in calendar month t, and zero otherwise. I compare treated offices against not-yet-treated and never-treated offices. Treatment timing varies across the 27 treated offices, creating a staggered adoption design.[8]

Collapsed difference-in-differences. For each treatment cohort g, defined by the calendar month D_g of the first arson attack within 25 km, I construct a sub-experiment pairing the offices treated at D_g with all not-yet-treated and never-treated offices, restricted to the 18-month event window $[D_g - 6,\ D_g + 11]$. Stacking the sub-experiments yields:

$$Y_{irdts} = \beta \cdot \text{Treated}_d \cdot \mathbf{1}(t \geqslant D_{g(s)}) + \alpha_{d,s} + \mu_{r,s} + \delta_{t,\tau,n,s} + X_i'\Gamma + \varepsilon_{irdts} \tag{5}$$

where Treated_d equals one for offices in treatment cohort $g(s)$ and zero for comparison offices (never-treated offices in the preferred specification, not-yet-treated offices in the alternative), s indexes sub-experiments, τ denotes months since application (duration), n denotes nationality, $g(s)$ maps each sub-experiment to its treatment cohort's attack month, and Γ is the coefficient vector on individual controls X_i. All fixed effects are interacted with the sub-experiment indicator: $\alpha_{d,s}$ (branch office × sub-experiment), $\mu_{r,s}$ (residence county × sub-experiment), and $\delta_{t,\tau,n,s}$ (calendar month × duration × nationality × sub-experiment), ensuring that each treated cohort is compared only against its own clean control group. X_i includes gender, birth year, a minor indicator, and time since arrival in Germany. Standard errors are clustered at the branch office level. The treatment coefficient β estimates the average change in the monthly probability of a positive decision across the twelve post-treatment months at treated offices. The 43 offices

[8] Similar identification strategies have been applied to assess mortality rates instead of approval rates (Miller et al., 2021).

provide the identifying variation, with 27 experiencing a first attack within 25 km during the sample period.

Event-study specification. To trace the temporal profile of the treatment effect and check pre-trends, I replace the post-treatment indicator with event-time dummies:

$$Y_{irdts} = \sum_{\substack{k=-6 \\ k\neq -1}}^{11} \beta_k \cdot \text{Treated}_d \cdot \mathbf{1}(t - D_{g(s)} = k) + \alpha_{d,s} + \mu_{r,s} + \delta_{t,\tau,n,s} + X_i'\Gamma + \varepsilon_{irdts} \qquad (6)$$

The coefficients β_k compare changes in approval probabilities at treated offices with changes at not-yet-treated or never-treated offices in the same sub-experiment, conditional on the specified fixed effects and individual controls.

6 Results

The preferred stacking estimator yields a reduction of 0.6 percentage points in the monthly probability of receiving any form of protection at offices exposed to a nearby arson attack (Table 2, column (1)), corresponding to a 24 percent decline relative to the sample mean of 2.6 percent.[9]

To express the monthly coefficient on an annual scale, consider an applicant who applies in the month of an attack, so that the entire first year after application falls into the post-attack period. At a constant monthly hazard of 2.6 percent, 27 percent of applicants are approved within 12 months, close to the descriptive 12-month rate of 27.3 percent in Table 1. Lowering the monthly hazard by 0.6 percentage points reduces this share to about 21 percent, a decline of about 5.7 percentage points, or roughly one fifth of 12-month approvals; the conventional 95 percent confidence interval corresponds to approximately 1 to 11 percentage points. This is a full-exposure benchmark: applicants whose applications were already pending when the attack occurred are exposed for only part of their first year. The survey evidence in Section 8.2 further suggests that the decline is concentrated among applicants interviewed in the month of an attack. Because waiting times between application and interview vary, an attack reaches applicants at different stages of their procedure, and applicants interviewed before the attack may be little affected.

[9]The stacking estimator constructs separate sub-experiments for each treatment cohort. Control observations are duplicated across sub-experiments, yielding 2,682,401 person-months from 95,320 unique persons in the never-treated comparison panel. The estimation sample contains 95,945 unique persons; the difference arises because the never-treated comparison drops observations that enter the stacked panel only as not-yet-treated controls, that is, applicants at later-treated offices who are observed only outside their own office's event window. Seven further persons are dropped because of missing covariates. Specifications that pool never-treated and not-yet-treated controls (Appendix Table C.3) retain 95,938 persons. The not-yet-treated comparison draws on fewer control observations and a lower-hazard mix of calendar months and durations, which accounts for its smaller sample and lower mean outcome.

Summed over exposed applicants, the coefficient implies a sizable number of forgone approvals. The estimation sample contains 364,544 at-risk person-months at treated offices after an attack; multiplied by the estimated decline of 0.607 percentage points, this gives about 2,200 fewer positive decisions (conventional 95 percent confidence interval roughly 300 to 4,100). Because applicants who are not approved remain at risk in later months, this product somewhat overstates forgone first-year approvals, by up to about 15 percent under the full-exposure benchmark above, so roughly 2,000 is a better summary. The research dataset is a 20 percent random sample of persons recorded in the register at the end of 2023, so the estimate corresponds to roughly 10,000 first-year approvals among comparable applicants at these offices (roughly 1,500 to 20,000). The figure covers only the offices and applicants in the estimation sample, and it counts approvals that did not occur within the first year after application: some of these applicants may have been approved later or on appeal. Finally, the stacked coefficient is a regression-weighted average of cohort-specific effects. Weighting each cohort's estimate by its treated person-months gives a similar total, to which the two cohorts first treated in January and May 2016 contribute most, while the remaining cohorts roughly offset each other.

Using the not-yet-treated comparison group, the estimate is -1.4 percentage points (SE 0.8) on a lower mean of 1.6 percent. This estimate is imprecise: its 95 percent confidence interval, approximately $[-2.9,\ 0.2]$ percentage points, contains both the never-treated estimate and zero. It is consistent in sign with the main estimate but cannot by itself distinguish a large effect from no effect.

Columns (3) and (4) of Table 2 use full refugee status as the outcome: refugee protection under the Geneva Convention or asylum under Article 16a of the Basic Law, the most generous forms of protection (Section 2.2; Appendix Table A.1). The risk set is the same as for any protection, so the outcome measures the monthly probability of a full-status grant among applicants without any protection decision yet. With the never-treated comparison group, this probability falls by 0.33 percentage points (SE 0.12) on a mean of 1.35 percent, a decline of about 24 percent (conventional 95 percent confidence interval roughly 7 to 42 percent). This estimate leans more heavily on parallel trends than the main one: in the corresponding event study, the pre-treatment coefficients for full refugee status are negative and drift toward the post-attack estimate, with the coefficients two and three months before the attack significant at the 5 and 10 percent levels. As with any protection, the not-yet-treated estimate in column (4) is larger and imprecise (-0.7 percentage points, SE 0.4). The decline in any protection in column (1) rules out a pure shift from full refugee status to subsidiary protection, which would leave column (1) unchanged. The implied change in the remaining forms of protection, the difference between columns (1) and (3), is -0.28 percentage points on a mean of 1.2 percent, but it is not separately estimated and is imprecise.

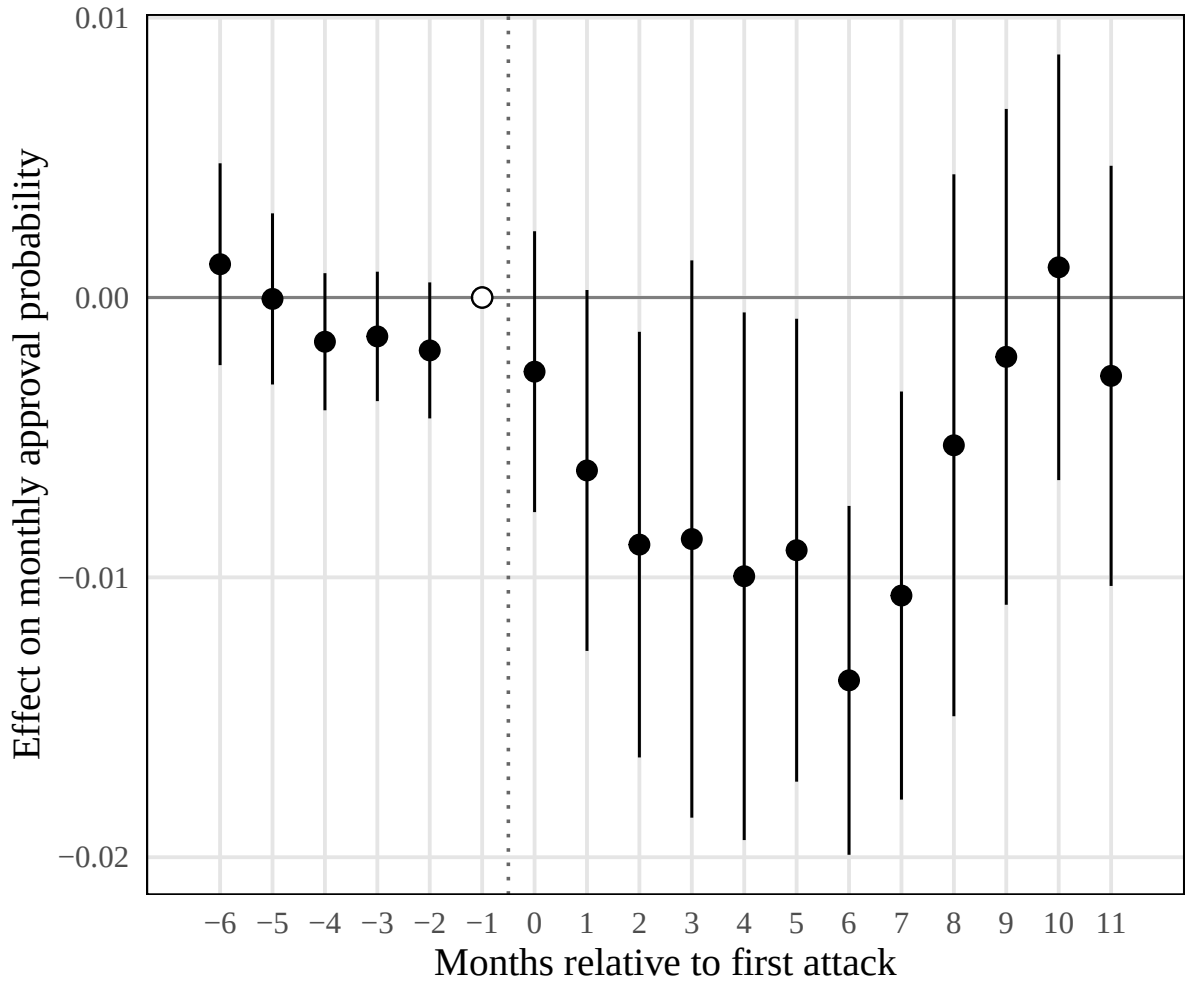


Figure 3: Effect of Arson Attacks on the Monthly Probability of a Positive Asylum Decision

Notes: Stacking estimator (Equation 6) following Baker et al. (2022), with never-treated offices as the comparison group. Coefficients show changes in the probability of receiving any form of protection relative to the month before treatment ($k = -1$, normalized to zero and shown as an open circle), over the event window $k = -6, \ldots, 11$; same specification as Table 2, column (1). Vertical bars indicate 95% normal-approximation confidence intervals ($\hat{\beta}_k \pm 1.96\,\mathrm{SE}$), using standard errors clustered at the branch office level. Sample: 95,320 applicants and 2,682,401 stacked person-months, 2015–2018. Source: AZR Research Dataset 2023; parliamentary interpellations (arson events).

Figure 3 presents the dynamic event-study coefficients from the stacking estimator. The pre-treatment coefficients are statistically insignificant, supporting the parallel-trends assumption. The estimated decline is statistically significant at the 5 percent level in month 2 and months 4–7, reaching its largest magnitude of 1.37 percentage points in month 6 (95 percent confidence interval 0.7 to 2.0). Between months 2 and 7 the coefficients range from 0.86 to 1.37 percentage points, or 34 to 53 percent of the mean monthly approval probability. From month 8 onward, the confidence intervals include zero. The delayed onset is consistent with the institutional lag between asylum interviews, where adjudication is concentrated, and the recording of decisions (see Appendix Figures A.3 and A.4 for processing durations by stage). If attacks affect officers' assessments during

interviews, this lag could explain why approval probabilities respond only after a delay.

Table 2: Effect of arson attacks on the monthly probability of a positive asylum decision (collapsed post-period)

	Any protection		Full refugee status	
	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Comparison group	Never treated	Not yet treated	Never treated	Not yet treated
Post × Treated	-0.006**	-0.014*	-0.003**	-0.007*
	(0.003)	(0.008)	(0.001)	(0.004)
Mean dep. var.	0.026	0.016	0.013	0.009
Observations	2,682,401	857,847	2,682,401	857,847
Persons	95,320	61,722	95,320	61,722
Fixed effects, each interacted with sub-experiment:				
Branch office	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Residence county	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Month × duration × nationality	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes

Notes: Dependent variable: binary indicator equal to one if the applicant receives the indicated form of protection in a given month. Columns (1) and (2): any form of protection; columns (3) and (4): full refugee status (refugee protection under the Geneva Convention or asylum under Art. 16a of the Basic Law). All columns use the risk set for any protection: applicant-months until the first positive decision or the 12-month censoring point. Columns (1) and (3) use the never-treated comparison group (95,320 applicants); columns (2) and (4) use the not-yet-treated comparison group (61,722 applicants). In columns (1) and (3) the unrounded point estimates correspond to declines of 24% relative to the respective sample means. The constructed sample contains 95,945 eligible applicants. Observations are stacked person-months: the same applicant-month can appear in more than one sub-experiment, while Persons counts distinct applicants within each regression sample. All specifications include demographic controls (gender, birth year, minor status, time since arrival). Standard errors clustered at the branch office level in parentheses. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

6.1 Robustness

The most direct robustness check restricts the sample to applicants whose residence county differs from their processing office county; the effect persists, reinforcing the interpretation of an office-side channel rather than an applicant-side response to local violence.[10] The estimate is also stable across five fixed-effect specifications (Appendix Table C.2), ranging from a parsimonious specification that enters duration, calendar month, and nationality effects separately to richer specifications that absorb residence county × calendar month shocks. All five specifications yield negative coefficients, significant at the 10 percent level or better. Absorbing residence county × calendar month shocks raises the estimate to −0.9 percentage points (SE 0.4; Appendix Table C.2, column (4)), and adding office state × calendar month effects leaves it unchanged (column (5)). Shocks common to an

[10] On the different-county subsample (79,137 persons), the estimate is −0.7 percentage points (SE 0.3), significant at the 1 percent level.

applicant's residence county, or to all offices in a state, in a given month therefore do not account for the decline; shocks specific to the office's locality remain the main residual threat (Section 7).

Assumption ID.2 requires that no successful appeal is observed within the observation window. Shortening the maximum observation window from 12 to 9, 6, or 3 months after application tightens this assumption, as shorter windows make it increasingly unlikely that any court decision contaminates the outcome. All three restricted windows yield negative estimates of -0.8 to -1.0 percentage points, significant at the 10 percent level or better (Appendix Table C.3), consistent with the results not being driven by successful appeals entering the observation window. These specifications pool never-treated and not-yet-treated comparison offices; with the same pooled comparison group and the full 12-month window, the estimate is -0.67 percentage points (SE 0.25), so the shorter windows yield larger estimates.

6.1.1 Office-Level Aggregate Statistics

A complementary check on the main results uses the office-level aggregate statistics described in Section 4.3.[11] Because the data are aggregated at the office level, they lack the demographic and processing-stage detail of the CRF sample used in the main analysis. Applicant behavior cannot be disentangled from immigration officer behavior at this level of aggregation. I therefore use these data as a robustness check rather than a primary specification.

The office-level data are well suited to verify two assumptions underlying the main identification. The aggregate counts include only first-instance decisions and exclude appeals, so any effect detected here cannot be driven by differential appeal behavior across treated and untreated offices. The data also allow a direct test of Assumption ID.3. If arson attacks shifted the timing of decisions rather than their content, the number of decisions at treated offices should decline.

I apply a stacking estimator to the office-level panel, using a continuous exposure measure that exploits within-year timing variation. For each treatment cohort, I pair treated offices with never-treated offices over pre-treatment and treatment years, interacting all fixed effects with the stack indicator. The exposure variable $E_d = (13 - m_d)/12$, where m_d is the calendar month of office d's first attack, assigns higher exposure to offices attacked earlier in the year (a January attack yields $E_d = 1$; a December attack yields $E_d \approx 0.08$). The sample covers 2015 to 2018, and excludes Syrian, Iraqi, and Eritrean nationalities, which received almost universal approval in 2015 through written procedures and therefore lack a meaningful pre-treatment period.

[11] I thank Martin Lange and co-authors for sharing the office-level aggregate data from Barreto et al. (2022).

Table 3 reports estimates from the stacking specification

$$Y_{dnys} = \alpha_{d,s} + \mu_{n,y,s} + \beta\, E_{ds} + \varepsilon_{dnys}, \tag{7}$$

where Y_{dnys} is the outcome for office d, nationality n, year y, and stack s. $\alpha_{d,s}$ are office × stack fixed effects and $\mu_{n,y,s}$ are nationality × year × stack fixed effects. E_{ds} equals the exposure measure for treated offices in their treatment year and zero otherwise. Columns (1) and (2) use the protection rate as the outcome, weighted by the number of decisions. Columns (3) and (4) use log decisions to test whether attacks shifted the volume of decisions.

The exposure coefficient on the protection rate is negative in both specifications but statistically significant only after adding state × year × stack fixed effects: the estimate in the parsimonious specification is −0.036 (SE 0.024, column 1), while adding state × year × stack fixed effects yields −0.068 ($p < 0.01$, column 2). The sensitivity to these additional controls likely reflects the coarseness of the yearly panel: with only 52 office units observed over four years (as coded in that source; the CRF estimation sample contains 43 offices), uncontrolled state-level trends in approval rates (driven, for example, by differential caseload composition across states) can attenuate or mask the exposure effect. The monthly person-level CRF data used in the main analysis absorb these trends through richer fixed-effect structures and yield a precisely estimated effect without relying on state × year controls. Despite the limited precision, the direction and magnitude of the office-level estimates are consistent with the main finding, and the estimate is obtained from an independent dataset that records only first-instance decisions and excludes appeals. The log-decisions placebo in columns (3) and (4) shows no significant effect on the volume of decisions at treated offices, consistent with Assumption ID.3: arson attacks shifted the content of decisions, not their timing or volume.

Table 3: Office-Level Aggregate Statistics

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
	Protection rate		Log decisions	
Exposure	−0.036	−0.068***	0.205	0.085
	(0.024)	(0.026)	(0.222)	(0.353)
Mean dep. var.	0.177	0.177	3.756	3.756
Observations	2,745	2,745	2,745	2,745
Offices	52	52	52	52
Treated	26	26	26	26
State × year × stack FE	No	Yes	No	Yes

Notes: Stacking estimator following Baker et al. (2022) with continuous exposure $E_d = (13 - \text{attack month})/12$. Cols. (1)–(2): protection rate (weighted by decisions); Cols. (3)–(4): log decisions (unweighted). Sample: 2015–2018, excluding Syrian, Iraqi, and Eritrean nationalities. Standard errors are clustered at office level. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

7 Threats to Identification

This section discusses the main threats to the design in Section 5.1: the timing of attacks, applicant composition, selective attrition, spillovers, institutional and staffing responses, and legal representation.

Exogeneity of attack timing. The identifying assumption requires that the timing of first arson attacks near immigration offices is uncorrelated with unobserved determinants of approval rates, conditional on the fixed effects. Arson attacks are not randomly assigned: they cluster in areas with rising anti-immigrant sentiment. The conceptual framework treats arson attacks as salient signals through which officers learn about local anti-immigrant sentiment. The identification concern is not that sentiment exists, but that offices may already be responding to the same underlying sentiment through other channels, such as colleague conversations, local media tone, or community attitudes, before the attack occurs. If so, the attack would be a symptom of sentiment that has already influenced decisions rather than an independent informational shock. Three features of the design mitigate this concern. First, the calendar month × nationality × duration fixed effects absorb nationwide sentiment shifts. Second, branch office fixed effects absorb time-invariant local attitudes. Third, residence county fixed effects absorb cross-county heterogeneity in applicants' locations, and the robustness specification that interacts residence county with calendar month (Appendix Table C.2) additionally absorbs time-varying shocks at the county level; the estimate is, if anything, larger under that specification. What remains unabsorbed is time-varying sentiment *specific to the branch office's locality* that correlates with attack timing. I cannot fully rule out this threat.

The event study's pre-treatment coefficients provide indirect evidence: in the preferred specification, none of the lead coefficients is statistically significant (Figure 3). The five pre-treatment coefficients are individually and jointly insignificant, though with a six-month pre-window, the test has limited power to detect violations that would meaningfully bias the post-treatment estimate (Roth, 2022). The design also requires a no-anticipation assumption: officers do not adjust decisions in response to attacks that have not yet occurred. Given that arson attacks are criminal acts without public advance notice, anticipation effects are unlikely.

Applicant composition. The identification strategy leverages the quasi-random allocation of refugees across German counties. While certain counties specialize in processing applications from specific countries of origin, these specializations remain largely stable over time. The key identifying assumption is that the distribution of refugees across German regions does not systematically change in correlation with local anti-immigrant sentiment. Even if counties attempted to select applicants based on local attitudes, the

specifications control for the refugee characteristics available for selection: country of origin, gender, age, minor status, and time since arrival. Appendix Figure B.1 examines this point using predicted approval rates, computed from cell means of nationality, calendar month, gender, family status, and minor status (Appendix B.1).

Selective attrition. The CRF does not retain records of individuals who naturalize. If naturalization rates differ between treated and control counties, the 2023 extract would disproportionately lose approved cases from the group with higher naturalization, biasing observed approval rates downward for that group.[12] The structural timeline limits this concern in either direction. The standard naturalization path requires 6–8 years of lawful residence, so applicants recognized in 2015 would satisfy the residence requirement in 2021 at the earliest. The results are robust to controlling for place of residence, meaning that for this channel to drive the results, it would need to operate through the processing location rather than residence. Appendix Table B.1 tests this directly by comparing treated and control counties on two administrative margins: register attrition, defined as the log ratio of protection-title holder counts between the 2021 and 2023 CRF extracts,[13] and cumulative naturalizations as a share of the county's foreign population. Neither measure differs significantly between treated and control counties, whether considering all counties or restricting to those hosting an immigration office. The latter comparison more closely mirrors the unit of treatment variation in the main analysis.

Spillover. The event study design assumes that arson attacks near one branch office do not affect decisions at other offices. Two types of spillover are relevant. First, geographic spillover: news coverage of an attack may affect applicants' behavior or legal-support availability near the attack site, independent of the processing office. Residence county fixed effects absorb level differences across applicants' locations, the residence county × calendar month robustness specification (Appendix Table C.2) absorbs time-varying local shocks, and the restriction to applicants whose residence county differs from their processing office county directly probes this channel (Section 6.1). Second, office-to-office spillover: staff at untreated offices may respond to attacks at distant offices through internal immigration office communication or national media coverage. If such spillover depresses approval rates at control offices, the treatment effect is attenuated; if it elevates them (e.g., through a compensatory response), the estimate is inflated. Under

[12] For attrition to generate the estimated negative treatment effect, treatment would need to *increase* naturalization among affected counties, removing more approved cases from the treated group and depressing its observed approval rate. The reverse channel, in which treatment lowers approval rates and thereby reduces naturalization eligibility, would attenuate the estimate toward zero.

[13] The main analysis uses the AZR Research Dataset 2023 (Gleiser and Salas Escobar, 2024). An earlier extract, the AZR Research Dataset 2021 (BAMF-Forschungsdatenzentrum, 2023), drawn before most applicants in the 2015–2018 cohort could have satisfied the residence requirement for naturalization, provides a pre-naturalization benchmark. This extract contains fewer variables and could not be used for the primary analysis, but suffices for comparing holder counts across cohorts. The ratio of holder counts between the two extracts captures all sources of register attrition.

non-uniform spillover, the dynamic coefficients can be distorted in either direction, and attenuation is not guaranteed. The design cannot test office-to-office spillover directly, because all comparison offices, never-treated and not-yet-treated alike, are equally exposed to internal communication and national media coverage. Spillover biases therefore cannot be ruled out.

Institutional and staffing responses. Immigration office leadership may have responded to arson attacks with internal directives, changes in oversight intensity, or personnel reallocation. These channels are distinct from individual officer discretion. If such institutional responses systematically lowered approval rates at affected offices, the estimated effect would conflate individual behavioral change with top-down institutional reactions. As discussed in Section 5.1, the federal structure of asylum adjudication limits any branch-office-level managerial reaction to procedural adjustments rather than substantive policy change. Without access to internal communications or personnel records, however, I cannot rule out procedural responses such as shifting case assignments or intensifying supervisory review at affected offices. After an internal audit in December 2017 uncovered irregularities at the Bremen branch office, the immigration office made the monitoring of branch-office protection rates a priority and ordered reviews of offices whose rates deviated by more than 10 percentage points from a country-composition-adjusted reference rate.[14] This reform falls at the trailing edge of the sample period, but its introduction confirms that headquarters recognized cross-office variation in adjudication as a quality concern.

A related concern is staffing. The immigration office's large-scale hiring during 2015–2017 raises the possibility of differential staffing responses at treated offices, which would conflate behavioral change among incumbent officers with compositional effects of new hires. Without officer-level identifiers in the CRF, I cannot directly separate these channels. The interview-format comparison in Section 8.1 does not resolve this concern: hiring expanded and personal interviews were reinstated at the same time in 2016, so a change in staff composition would also show up mainly in interview cases.

Legal representation. Arson attacks may trigger increased legal aid or NGO mobilization near affected areas, which could independently affect approval rates by improving case preparation. Since applicants reside in different counties from their processing offices, this channel would need to operate through the applicant's residence county rather than the office's locality. Residence county fixed effects absorb time-invariant differences in legal support across applicant locations, and the residence county $\times$ calendar month robustness specification (Appendix Table C.2) additionally absorbs time-varying differences,

[14] The reference rate weights each branch office's nationality mix by the national approval rate per nationality, producing a counterfactual mean against which the office's actual rate is compared (BT-Drs. 19/2483, answer to question 9; BT-Drs. 19/3148, answer to question 4).

limiting this channel to within-county-month variation in legal mobilization.

8 Mechanisms

8.1 Personal Interview as the Site of Discretion

The main results rely on the institutional argument that officer discretion is concentrated at the personal interview. A separate policy change provides evidence on this claim. From autumn 2014, the immigration office processed claims from Syrian, Eritrean, and Iraqi-minority applicants through simplified written procedures without individual interviews. Decrees of the Federal Ministry of the Interior then reinstated personal interviews: first for applicants arriving on or after 1 January 2016 and, from 17 March 2016, for all new applications regardless of entry date.[15] This creates within-office variation in interview format among applicants processed at the same branch office.

The specification is estimated on Syrian, Iraqi, and Eritrean applicants (the nationalities eligible for the written procedure) who filed between January 2015 and December 2016. Unlike the main estimation sample, this sample retains written-procedure cases and is not subject to the regular-application and universal-rejection filters; never-treated and not-yet-treated offices both serve as comparison offices. The specification absorbs branch-office fixed effects (interacted with the sub-experiment indicator) and allows county-level trends and the baseline hazard to differ across interview formats through personal-interview-by-county-by-calendar-month and personal-interview-by-duration-by-calendar-month-by-nationality fixed effects. The post-attack coefficient is identified from within-office variation over time and captures the arson effect on applicants processed via written procedure. The interaction captures the additional effect for applicants adjudicated with a personal interview. The reinstatement of personal interviews coincided with other policy changes;[16] the interview-format-by-county-by-calendar-month fixed effects absorb any uniform effects of the broader policy package, isolating the interview-format margin.

Table 4 interacts the post-arson-attack indicator with the personal interview indicator. Column (1) uses any form of protection as the outcome; column (2) uses full refugee status. For applicants processed via written procedure, the post-attack coefficient is close to zero in both columns (0.004, SE 0.014, in column 1), but its 95% confidence interval, approximately $[-0.023,\ 0.031]$, cannot rule out moderate effects in either direction. The

[15] The CRF does not record whether an interview took place. The personal interview indicator is therefore assigned by rule: it equals one if the applicant arrived on or after 1 January 2016 or filed on or after 17 March 2016, that is, if the applicant was no longer eligible for the written procedure. Iraqi applicants, who were only partially subject to the original written procedure, are included in the analysis.

[16] The reinstatement was timed to coincide with *Asylpaket II*, in force from 17 March 2016, which among other measures suspended family reunification for holders of subsidiary protection for two years (BT-Drs. 18/9992, answer to question 8).

interaction term is large, negative, and highly significant (-0.047, SE 0.010): the decline is concentrated among applicants whose claims were adjudicated with a personal interview. The size of the interaction depends on how finely time is controlled within offices. When branch-office × calendar-month fixed effects are added, so that interview and written-procedure cases are compared at the same office in the same month, the interaction shrinks to -0.015 (SE 0.008, significant at the 10 percent level) for any protection and to -0.025 (SE 0.006) for full refugee status.

Two readings of this pattern are possible. Under the first, local hostility enters adjudication through the interview, where officers assess the applicant's credibility in person. Under the second, written-procedure cases were approved almost universally, so there was little discretion for an attack to act on, whatever the format. The test cannot fully separate these readings. Moreover, because the officer who interviews and the officer who decides could differ in 2016 (Section 2.2), the indicator marks cases *with an interview*, not cases decided by the officer who met the applicant. The survey evidence in Section 8.2 speaks to the timing question under either reading: approval falls when the attack coincides with the applicant's interview month, not with the decision month.

The magnitudes are not directly comparable to the main estimate. The interview-format sample covers 2015–2016 and three nationalities with high approval rates, its baseline monthly approval probability (0.105) is about four times that of the main sample, and the specification identifies a difference between interview formats rather than a decomposition of the main effect.

8.2 Survey evidence on approval rates

The preceding results rely on administrative data that does not include information on interview dates. An independent test uses individual-level data from the IAB-BAMF-SOEP refugee survey, where respondents report when their interview took place and whether their claim was approved. The main shortcoming of the survey data is that it does not include information on the assigned immigration office. The treatment definition therefore has to be based on the residence of an applicant. I exclude any individuals with an arson attack within their county (of which there are 423) and assign their applications as treated if there is an arson attack within the coarser planning region (96 regions). The survey is not fully representative of all asylum applications as it is restricted to nationalities classified as having a good prospect of approval at the time of sampling. On top of the nationality dimension, oversampling was also applied to women and persons aged over 30. The cross-sectional specification estimates:

$$Y_i = \beta_1 D_{r(i),t} + \beta_2 D_{r(i),t} \times N_{r(i),t} + X_i'\Gamma + \mu_t + \varepsilon_i \tag{8}$$

where Y_i equals one if respondent i reports a positive asylum decision. $D_{r(i),t}$ indicates whether any arson attack occurred in the respondent's planning region r (excluding the

Table 4: Arson Effect by Interview Format

	(1) Any protection	(2) Full refugee
Post-Attack	0.004	0.000
	(0.014)	(0.013)
Post-Attack × Personal Interview	-0.047***	-0.054***
	(0.010)	(0.010)
Mean dep. var.	0.105	0.074
Observations	1,872,610	2,077,281
Persons	71,309	71,309

Notes: Post-arson-attack indicator and its interaction with a personal interview indicator. Column (1): dependent variable is any form of protection; column (2): full refugee status. Sample: Syrian, Iraqi, and Eritrean applicants (the nationalities eligible for the written procedure) who filed January 2015–December 2016, including written-procedure cases. The personal interview indicator equals one for applicants who arrived on or after 1 January 2016 or filed on or after 17 March 2016. All specifications include branch office × sub-experiment, personal interview × county × calendar month × sub-experiment, and personal interview × duration × calendar month × nationality × sub-experiment fixed effects, as well as demographic controls (gender, birth year, minor status, time since arrival). Standard errors clustered at the branch office level in parentheses. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

respondent's own county) during month t, defined alternately by the interview month or the decision month. $N_{r(i),t}$ is the Nexis newspaper article count for attacks in the region, standardized to one standard deviation. X_i includes personal characteristics, and μ_t absorb monthly fixed effects. Standard errors are clustered at the planning region level. I also estimate an event-study variant replacing $D_{r(i),t}$ with relative-month indicators $\mathbf{1}(t - D_{r(i)} = k)$ for $k \in \{-5, \ldots, 5\}$.

Table 5 tests whether the effect operates through interview-month or decision-month exposure and whether news coverage amplifies it. Columns (1)–(2) define treatment by the interview month; columns (3)–(4) by the decision month. Binary arson exposure at the interview month significantly reduces approval probability (column 1). Adding an interaction with newspaper coverage (column 2), the interaction is negative and significant, indicating that attacks receiving more press coverage produce larger effects, while the binary coefficient attenuates. When treatment is instead defined by the decision month (columns 3–4), the binary coefficient is close to zero and insignificant, consistent with the personal interview, where personal discretion of immigration officers is highest, as the site where local conditions enter adjudication.

Figure 4 presents event-study coefficients from this specification. Panel (a) plots the binary arson effect. Pre-treatment coefficients are close to zero and statistically insignificant. The approval probability drops sharply in the month of the arson attack. Subsequent coef-

Table 5: Arson Exposure and Approval Probability (SOEP)

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)
Arson	-0.049**	-0.029	0.011	0.008
	(0.020)	(0.024)	(0.018)	(0.021)
Arson × News		-0.010*		0.002
		(0.005)		(0.002)
Observations	3,044	3,044	2,917	2,917
Timing	Interview	Interview	Decision	Decision
Mean dep. var.	0.859	0.859	0.863	0.863

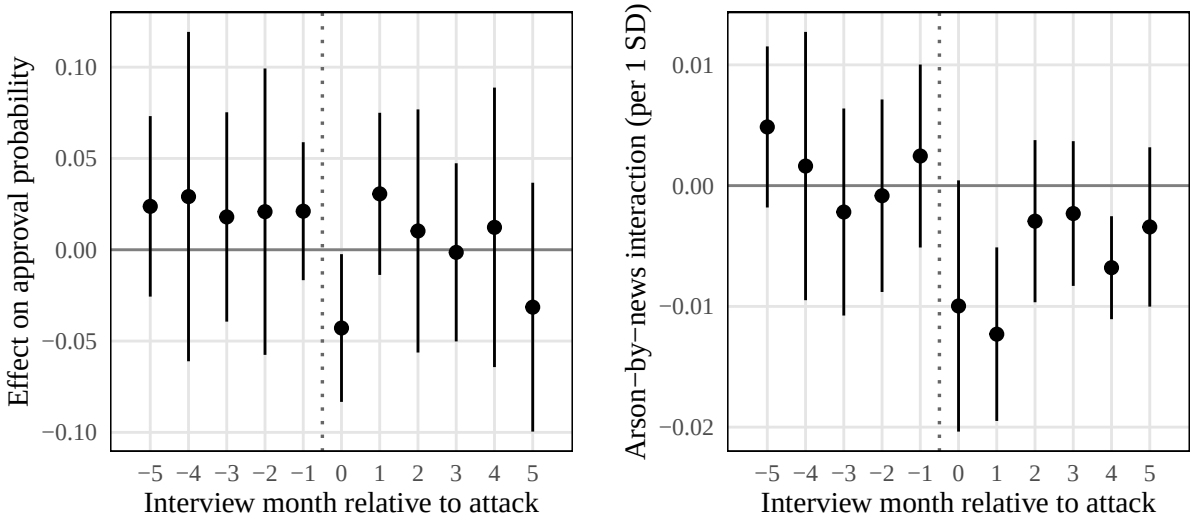
Notes: Linear probability models. Dependent variable: individual asylum approval (SOEP self-report). "Arson": binary indicator for any arson attack in the respondent's planning region (excluding own county) during the relevant month. "Arson × News": interaction with Nexis newspaper article count (standardized to 1 SD). Columns (1)–(2) define treatment by interview month; columns (3)–(4) by decision month. All specifications include calendar-month fixed effects, controlling for gender, age at interview, and immigration office administrative approval rate. Standard errors clustered at the planning-region (Raumordnungsregion) level in parentheses. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

ficients are imprecisely estimated and do not show a persistent decline. Panel (b) plots the interaction between binary arson exposure and the news article count (per one standard deviation). Pre-treatment interaction coefficients are close to zero. After treatment, the interaction turns negative, indicating that within the set of exposed respondents, those whose local attacks received more press coverage experienced larger declines in approval probability. The pattern is consistent with a transient salience channel in which media coverage amplifies the initial signal of local hostility.

These results triangulate the main administrative findings using an independently collected survey. The SOEP sample is small ($N = 3{,}044$ under interview-month timing) and treatment is defined at a different geographic level (planning region rather than branch office), so the estimates are noisier than the main specification. The direction of the approval decline replicates across data sources, while the media-salience channel is identified only in the survey and should be read as suggestive: the interaction rests on a single cross-sectional specification without region fixed effects, comparing across planning regions with and without a contemporaneous attack rather than tracking within-region changes.

8.3 Beliefs

I use survey data from the SOEP to test how attacks against refugees shifted beliefs near immigration offices. Only counties that host an immigration office branch enter the sample. I construct a stacked difference-in-differences design paralleling the main



(a) Binary arson exposure

(b) Arson × news coverage interaction

Figure 4: Event study: arson exposure and individual approval (SOEP)

Notes: Panel (a): coefficients on relative-month indicators from an individual-level regression of asylum approval. Treatment: nearest arson attack in the same ROR, excluding the respondent's own county. Reference category: applicants with no arson within ±5 months (Emeriau, 2024). Panel (b): interaction coefficients from separate cross-sectional regressions at each offset k, interacting binary arson exposure with the Nexis article count (standardized to 1 SD). Controls: gender, age at interview, immigration office administrative approval rate. Calendar-month fixed effects. Standard errors clustered at the planning region level. Error bars show 95% confidence intervals. Data: IAB-BAMF-SOEP refugee survey, 2016–2019; arson events from parliamentary interpellations; Nexis newspaper coverage.

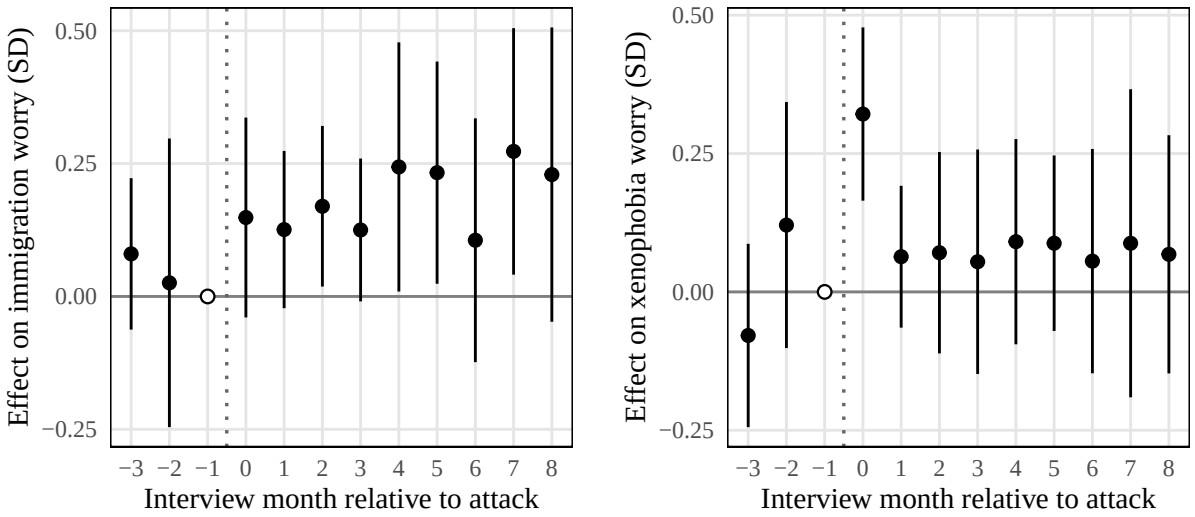
specification, comparing SOEP respondents in treated immigration office counties against respondents in never-treated immigration office counties. The event-study specification is:

$$\tilde{W}_{ics} = \sum_{\substack{k=-3 \\ k\neq -1}}^{8} \beta_k \cdot \mathbf{1}(k_s = k) \cdot D_c + \phi \tilde{W}_{i,s-1} + \alpha_{g,s} + \mu_{k,s} + \varepsilon_{ics} \tag{9}$$

where $\tilde{W}_{ics}$ is the worry outcome for respondent i in county c and sub-experiment s, standardized by the pre-treatment standard deviation. D_c indicates whether the respondent resides in a county whose immigration office was exposed to a nearby arson attack; all respondents in the sample reside in counties that host an immigration office branch. The coefficients β_k are identified by comparing the evolution of worry outcomes between treated and never-treated office counties around each attack. Because interview dates vary across respondents within each SOEP wave, the event window typically contains only one observation per respondent, so the identifying variation is cross-sectional: it compares respondents interviewed before the attack to those interviewed after, in treated versus control counties. $\tilde{W}_{i,s-1}$ is the lagged outcome from the previous survey wave, which exploits the panel dimension of the SOEP to control for prior attitudes. The fixed effects $\alpha_{g,s}$ (treatment group × sub-experiment) and $\mu_{k,s}$ (month bin × sub-experiment) absorb group-level means and common time patterns within each sub-experiment. Standard errors are clustered at the county level.

Figure 5 presents event-study coefficients for respondents residing in treated immigration office counties, expressed in pre-treatment standard deviations. Pre-treatment coefficients are statistically insignificant for both outcomes. If anything, immigration worry displays a declining trend before treatment, making the post-attack increase a conservative estimate. The two outcomes display distinct temporal patterns. Xenophobia worry spikes sharply in the month of the attack but falls sharply by month 1 and becomes statistically indistinguishable from zero thereafter. Immigration worry rises more modestly at impact and remains elevated over subsequent months, though confidence intervals widen substantially at longer horizons. Arson attacks trigger an immediate concern about xenophobic hostility that fades as the event recedes from public attention, while worries about immigration accumulate as the local salience of the refugee issue persists.

The short-lived increase in concern for refugee safety aligns with Freitas-Monteiro and Prömel (2024), who show a short-term increase in pro-refugee beliefs after large far-right protests at the national level, and with Emeriau (2024), who documents a short-run empathy response in approval rates after migrant shipwrecks. The more persistent pattern of immigration worry is also consistent with the voting responses to far-right terrorist attacks documented by Sabet et al. (2023) and with the longer-lasting decrease in approval rates found in the main results.



(a) Immigration worry

(b) Xenophobia worry

Figure 5: Event study: public attitudes in treated counties

Notes: Stacked difference-in-differences event-study coefficients. Dependent variables are SOEP worry items (1–3 scale, increasing in concern), standardized by the pre-treatment standard deviation. Treatment: first arson attack in the respondent's county of residence. Control group: respondents in never-treated immigration office counties. Reference period: month −1 (open circle). All specifications include cohort×treated and cohort×month-bin fixed effects, controlling for lagged immigration worry, xenophobia worry, and social cohesion worry. Standard errors clustered at the county level. Error bars show 95% confidence intervals. Data: SOEP v41, 2015–2019.

8.4 Heterogeneity

Appendix Table C.1 reports separate stacking regressions by subgroup, each estimated against the full never-treated comparison group. Point estimates are larger in areas with below-median AfD vote share in the 2013 federal election (−1.0 versus −0.3 percentage points), for aggravated than for simple arson (−0.8 versus −0.4), and for male than for female applicants (−0.8 versus −0.3). Pooled regressions that interact the post-attack indicator with continuous measures test two of these dimensions directly. The interaction with the 2013 AfD vote share is positive and significant at the 1 percent level: the decline is smaller where far-right support was higher. For severity, an indicator for exposure consisting only of aggravated attacks yields an insignificant interaction (−0.4 percentage points, SE 0.4). The decline is larger at offices hit by more than one attack in their first month of exposure: each additional attack within 25 km in that month lowers the monthly approval probability by a further 0.4 percentage points (SE 0.2, significant at the 5 percent level), and the interaction with the number of aggravated attacks is of similar size. This dose-response pattern is identified from the few offices with several attacks in their first month of exposure, and these interaction regressions omit the individual controls, so it should be read as suggestive. If the AfD pattern reflects a real difference, one speculative interpretation is that an attack is more informative about local hostility where such hostility is otherwise less visible. The severity results show no weaker response to attacks that endanger lives, so the protective-action and backlash pathways of Section 3 do not dominate, although these tests cannot rule them out.

8.5 Summary of the Mechanism Evidence

The evidence in this section speaks to where discretion enters adjudication (cases with an interview, and the interview month in the survey data) and to how residents' attitudes respond (immigration worry persists while xenophobia worry fades). It does not separate the belief channel from the perceived-expectations channel of Section 3: both predict the same sign, and neither officers' attitudes nor their perceptions of local expectations are observed. The SOEP attitudes measure residents of office counties, not officers. The protective-action and backlash pathways are tested only indirectly, through the severity interactions and the short-lived xenophobia worry, and the net negative effect indicates that they do not dominate on average.

9 Limitations

Office-level estimand. I observe decisions at the branch-office level and cannot identify individual officers. The estimate is an office-level adjudication response. Because the immigration office hired on a large scale during 2015–2017 and, in 2016, the interviewing and the deciding officer could differ, I cannot distinguish behavioral change among

incumbent officers from changes in staff composition or case assignment (Section 7).

Interview dates and survey treatment. The CRF records application and decision dates but not interview dates, so the treatment-relevant window is approximated by duration since application. The survey evidence that ties the effect to the interview month assigns treatment by the applicant's planning region of residence, because the survey does not record the processing office; it therefore measures exposure near applicants rather than near offices.

Few clusters. Inference relies on standard errors clustered at the branch-office level, with 43 clusters of which 27 are treated, and cluster sizes are unbalanced, from fewer than 20 to more than 8,000 applicants per office (Appendix Table A.4). Conventional cluster-robust standard errors can understate uncertainty in this setting.

Censoring beyond 12 months. The outcome captures approvals within 12 months of application. In the estimation sample, 27.3 percent of applicants are approved within 12 months and 42.3 percent ever (Table 1). The design identifies a shift in first-instance approvals within the first year; it does not identify effects on approvals that occur later, including those following successful appeals.

Treatment definition. Treatment is defined by the first arson attack within 25 km of a branch office. Subsequent attacks are not coded separately, and the analysis does not control for office workload or regional inflows of applicants, which could co-move with attacks.

Multiple comparisons. The event study estimates 17 event-time coefficients, and the heterogeneity analysis examines several subgroups and interactions. I do not apply multiple-testing corrections; the interpretation rests on the joint pattern of post-attack coefficients rather than on any individual coefficient.

External validity. The findings are specific to the German institutional context, with centralized federal processing and geographic separation between offices and applicants. Whether the permeability of administrative decisions to local political violence extends to other bureaucracies or countries is a hypothesis for future work.

10 Conclusion

This paper uses geographic separation between processing offices and applicant residences in the German asylum system to test whether far-right violence compromises high-stakes administrative decisions. Arson attacks against refugee accommodations reduce the monthly approval probability at nearby branch offices by 0.6 percentage points (24 percent relative to the mean), or about 6 percentage points in the 12-month approval rate for an applicant exposed throughout the first year after application. In the estimation sample, this amounts to roughly 2,000 fewer first-year approvals, on the order of 10,000 among comparable applicants once the 20 percent research sample is scaled up. The decline is smaller in regions with higher far-right support and larger where several attacks occurred in the first month of exposure, while attacks that endanger human life show no weaker response. A within-office comparison suggests that the decline is concentrated in cases adjudicated with a personal interview; written-procedure cases, which were approved almost universally, show no detectable response. Far-right violence can, in sum, shift the outcomes of a process designed to reflect the merits of each individual claim.

What makes these findings distinct is that the hostility signal is majority-perpetrated violence against a vulnerable minority. Unlike minority-perpetrated attacks (Shayo and Zussman, 2011; Brodeur and Wright, 2019), arson attacks on refugee housing offer no rational basis for updating threat assessments, yet the bureaucratic response mirrors them. Survey evidence on residents' attitudes is consistent with compliance dominating resistance: the hostile signal accumulates in the local environment while sympathy for victims fades, providing a plausible attitudinal pathway through which the political climate enters the adjudication room. The results point toward concrete safeguards. Structured interviews with standardized question catalogs could limit the scope for subjective assessment. Systematic training and feedback of the kind Emeriau (2023) shows can reduce bias among asylum officers would address the individual-level channel, while rotation of caseworkers across regions could insulate offices from persistent local conditions. More broadly, wherever public servants exercise discretion within the boundaries of formal rules (Lipsky, 2010), their decisions may absorb the political climate of their environment; whether this vulnerability extends to other policy areas is an open question.

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A Institutional Details and Data

A.1 Institutional Details

Internal Quality Assurance. The immigration office operates a dual-review principle under which a second reviewer checks each asylum decision before dispatch. During the 2015–2016 caseload surge, internal oversight was substantially weakened: the central quality-assurance unit reviewed approximately 1% of the 282,700 decisions rendered in 2015, and the dual-review requirement was made formally binding by central directive only in September 2017.[17] A mandatory random 10% pre-dispatch quality check was introduced in May 2018 following the discovery of procedural irregularities at the Bremen branch office. These dates imply that for much of the sample period (2015–mid-2017), the institutional constraints on individual officer discretion were weaker than the standing procedural framework would suggest.

[17] Source: parliamentary inquiries BT-Drs. 19/4853 and testimony by the immigration office staff council before the Interior Committee in 2018.

Table A.1: Types of International Protection in Germany

Protection Status	**Requirements**	**Legal Basis**	**Residence Duration**	**Family Reunification**	**Permanent Residency**
Asylum (Art. 16a GG)	Political persecution by state actors; must enter directly from a non-safe country	German Basic Law (Grundgesetz)	3 years	Yes (easier, no waiting period)	After 3 years
Refugee Protection	Persecution due to race, religion, nationality, political opinion, or social group	Geneva Refugee Convention, §3 AsylG	3 years	Yes (easier, no waiting period)	After 3 years
Subsidiary Protection	No individual persecution but serious harm (e.g., death penalty, torture, war-related threats)	§4 AsylG	1 year (extendable to 3)	Restricted (2-year waiting period, proof of financial means required)	After 5 years
National Ban on Deportation	Risk of inhumane treatment or life-threatening situation in home country, but no refugee/subsidiary protection status	§60 Abs. 5/7 AufenthG	1 year (renewable)	Restricted (must prove financial stability)	After 7 years

Notes: Overview of protection categories under German asylum law as of 2015–2018 (the sample period). Legal bases: German Basic Law (Art. 16a GG), Asylum Act (AsylG), and Residence Act (AufenthG). Residence permit durations and family reunification rules reflect the legal framework during the study period. Source: Federal Office for Migration and Refugees procedural guidelines.

Table A.2: Classification of Arson Offenses (German Criminal Code)

Category	StGB §	German Title	Official English Title	Key Statutory Elements
Simple arson				
Simple	§ 306	Brandstiftung	Arson	Sets fire to or destroys buildings, plants, warehouses, motor vehicles, forests, or agricultural facilities belonging to another (1–10 years)
Simple	§ 306d	Fahrlässige Brandstiftung	Negligent arson	Acts negligently in cases under § 306(1) or § 306a(1), or causes danger under § 306a(2) by negligence ($\leqslant$5 years)
Aggravated arson				
Aggravated	§ 306a	Schwere Brandstiftung	Aggravated arson	Sets fire to premises serving to accommodate people, churches, or premises where people are usually present ($\geqslant$1 year)
Aggravated	§ 306b	Besonders schwere Brandstiftung	Especially aggravated arson	Causes serious health damage or places another in danger of death; acts to facilitate another offence or prevents extinguishing ($\geqslant$2 years; $\geqslant$5 years for danger of death)
Aggravated	§ 308	Herbeiführen einer Sprengstoffexplosion	Causing explosion	Causes an explosion, in particular using explosives, and thereby endangers life, limb, or property of significant value ($\geqslant$1 year)

Notes: Classification of arson offenses under the German Criminal Code (*Strafgesetzbuch*, StGB). Section titles and statutory elements are from the official English translation provided by the Federal Ministry of Justice (gesetze-im-internet.de). Penalty ranges in parentheses. Simple arson covers § 306 and § 306d. Aggravated arson covers § 306a, § 306b, and § 308, the categories that endanger human life, used as the severity indicator in the mechanism analysis.

A.2 Descriptive Statistics

Table A.3: Descriptive Statistics: Asylum Applications

	Stacked observations	Unique applicants
Panel A: Construction of the eligible sample		
Unrestricted stacked panel	6,426,097	162,537
After regular-procedure restrictions	3,572,100	96,132
After nationality-month outcome filter	3,564,490	95,945
At risk of first positive decision	3,223,576	95,945
Panel B: Timing relative to the office's first attack		
Never-treated offices	2,321,652	33,938
Treated offices, before attack ($k < 0$)	84,338	20,536
Treated offices, attack month ($k = 0$)	19,396	19,396
Treated offices, after attack ($k > 0$)	798,190	61,682
Panel C: Offices in the constructed sample		
Treated during 2015–2018	27	
Never treated	16	
Total offices	43	

Notes: Panel A constructs the eligible administrative sample before specification-specific regression restrictions. Observations are stacked person-month records, so an applicant-month may appear in several sub-experiments. Regular-procedure restrictions require residence and processing office in the same federal state, exclude written procedures and designated special-processing offices (the Nuremberg headquarters, decision centers including the Bonn branch, and special units including the Berlin arrival center and the Frankfurt Airport transit office), require application duration of at least 30 days, and retain offices with more than 100 applicants in the source population. The nationality-month filter excludes cells with approval rates above 98%. Panel B partitions the eligible stacked observations by an office's own attack date; $k = 0$ is the attack month. Its observation counts sum to 3,223,576. The attack-month count is obtained by subtraction; each such applicant-month occurs only in its own treatment cohort. Unique applicants can appear in several timing rows, so those counts are not additive. Panel C reports 43 offices from the 48-office CRF frame. Source: AZR Research Dataset 2023 (FDZ release of May 2026, sample-construction output).

Table A.4: Branch Office Treatment Roster

Treated offices			Never-treated offices		
Office	First attack	N	Office	First attack	N
Dresden	2015-01	19	Bad Fallingbostel	–	2,988
Hamburg	2015-02	1,049	Bamberg	–	944
Nostorf-Horst	2015-02	1,126	Bayreuth	–	477
Manching	2015-04	116	Bramsche	–	3,673
Heidelberg	2015-05	1,391	Buedingen	–	1,553
Karlsruhe	2015-07	3,742	Deggendorf	–	1,326
Chemnitz	2015-07	2,954	Jena-Hermsdorf	–	1,433
Halberstadt	2015-08	2,610	Moenchengladbach	–	3,515
Leipzig	2015-08	603	Neumuenster	–	3,417
Bremen	2015-09	882[a]	Neustadt	–	850
Dortmund	2015-09	4,484	Oldenburg	–	1,260
Unna	2015-09	981	Regensburg	–	1,287
Essen	2015-09	1,362	Schweinfurt	–	1,298
Bochum	2015-09	116	Sigmaringen	–	997
Friedland	2015-10	1,995	Trier	–	4,201
Eisenhuettenstadt	2015-10	3,260	Zirndorf	–	4,719
Augsburg	2015-12	761			
Braunschweig I	2016-01	3,251			
Ellwangen	2016-01	2,310			
Muenchen	2016-03	5,251			
Giessen	2016-05	8,205			
Bielefeld	2016-05	6,906			
Duesseldorf	2016-06	4,035			
Koeln-Bonn	2016-06	1,815			
Suhl	2017-01	1,315			
Freiburg	2017-04	586			
Lebach	2017-06	881			

Notes: The 43 branch offices represented in the constructed administrative sample (27 treated, 16 never-treated). Treated offices experienced a first arson attack within 25 km during 2015–2018; the first attack month is shown. Never-treated offices had no nearby arson attack during 2015–2018. N counts distinct eligible applicants by office before specification-specific regression restrictions, pooling disclosed cells across treatment periods. The earliest treatment cohorts (first attacked in early 2015) contribute few or no pre-treatment months. The Berlin arrival center, Bonn branch, Frankfurt Airport transit office, and Nuremberg headquarters are excluded (Table A.3). [a] Bremen has an additional suppressed cell with fewer than three applicants; its displayed count excludes that cell. Disclosed office counts exclude suppressed cells and therefore need not sum to the full constructed-sample count of 95,945. Source: AZR Research Dataset 2023 (FDZ release of May 2026, office-level descriptive output); parliamentary interpellations (arson events).

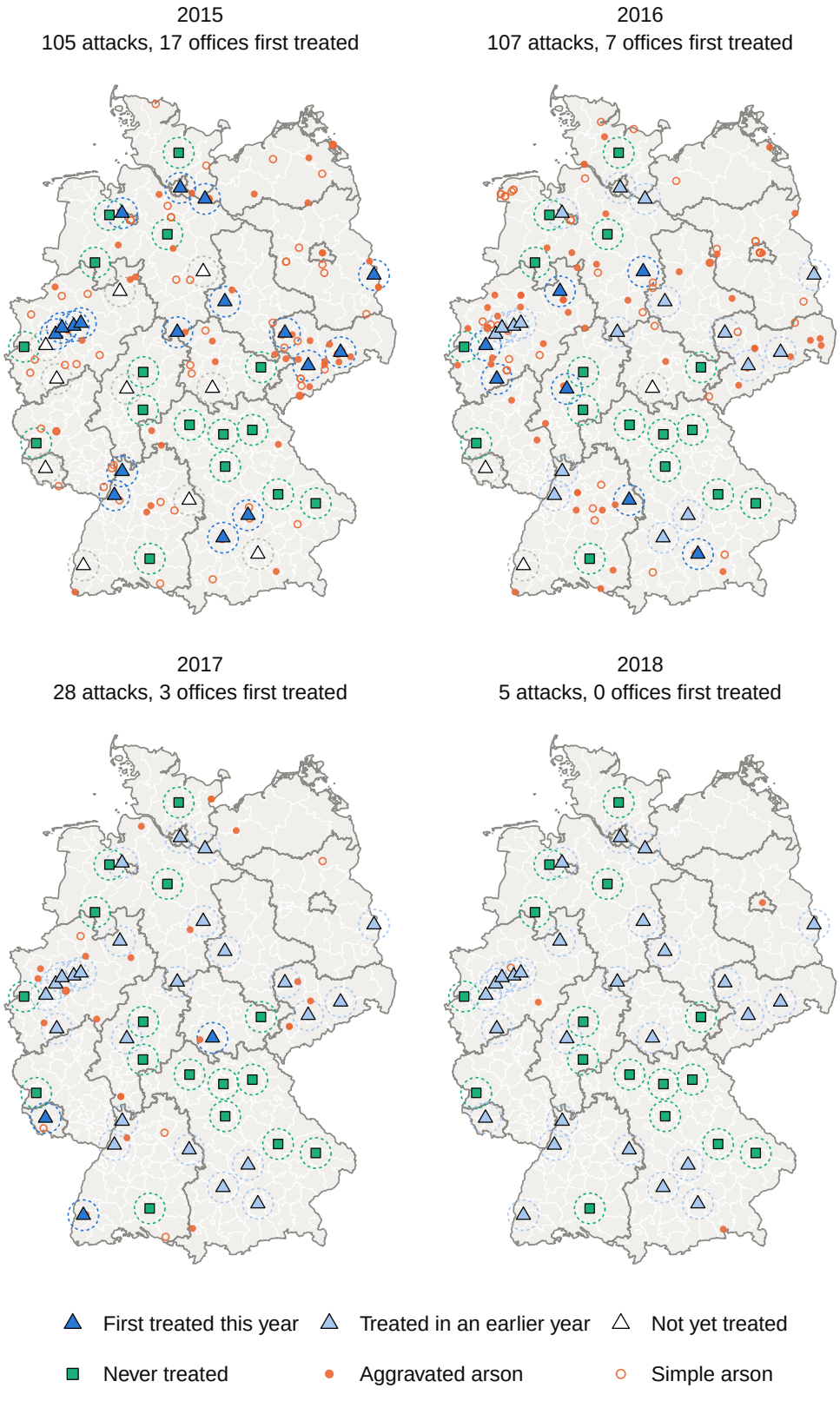


Figure A.1: Arson Attacks and Branch Offices by Year

Notes: Figure 1 drawn separately for each year. Each panel shows the arson attacks on refugee accommodations recorded in that year (filled: aggravated arson; open: simple arson). Of these, 35 (2015), 24 (2016), 9 (2017), and 2 (2018) occurred within 25 km of an office in the estimation sample. Triangles mark the 27 treated offices, shaded by the year of their first attack within 25 km: dark blue in that year, light blue in later years, and white in earlier years, before the office is treated. Squares mark the 16 never-treated offices; dashed circles show the 25 km treatment radius. The year of first treatment matches the first attack month in Table A.4 for every treated office. No office is first treated in 2018; the last cohort (Lebach) is first treated in June 2017. Sources as in Figure 1.

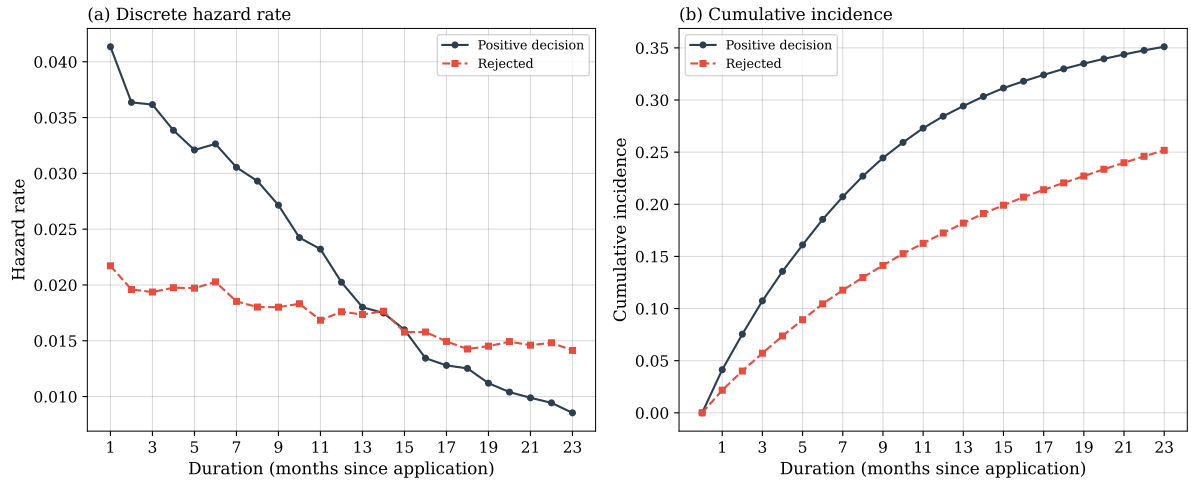


Figure A.2: Decision Hazard and Cumulative Incidence in the Estimation Sample

Notes: Panel (a) plots the discrete-time hazard rate: the share of the at-risk population receiving a decision in each month after application, separately for positive decisions (refugee status under AsylG or GFK, subsidiary protection, or deportation ban) and rejections. Panel (b) plots the corresponding cumulative incidence: the cumulative share of the initial population that has received each decision type by month t. Month 24 is a right-censored catch-all (applications with Dublin transfers, cancellations, or pending status) and is excluded from the plotted range. Data pooled over application years 2015–2018. Source: AZR Research Dataset 2023.

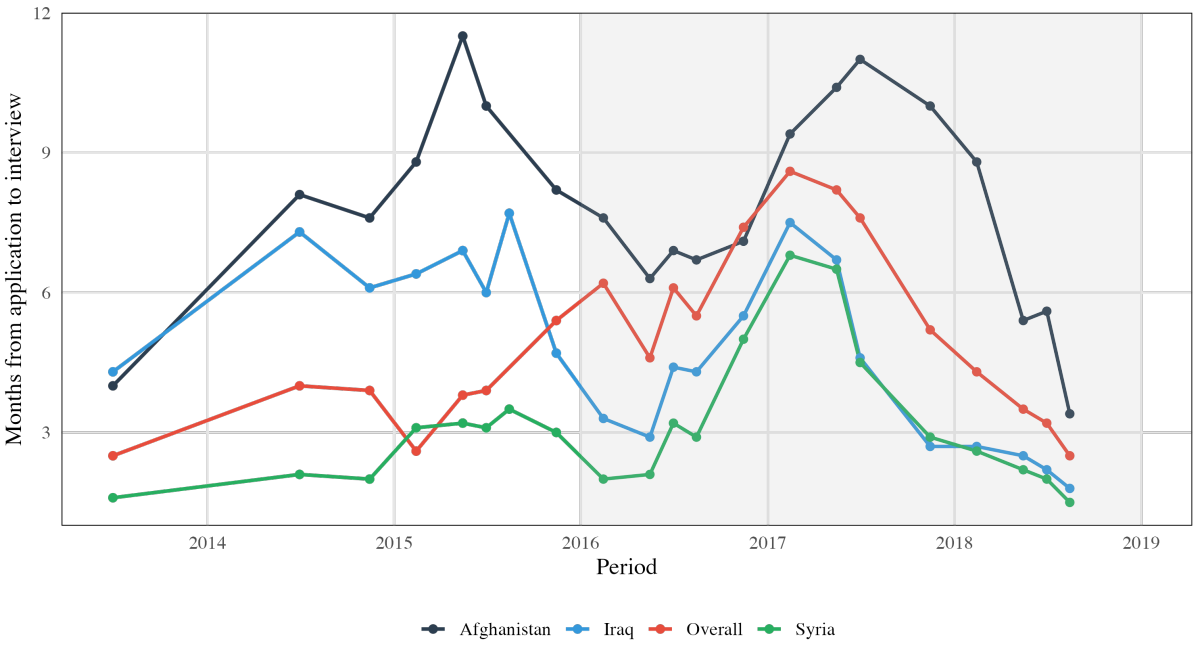


Figure A.3: Duration from Application to Interview

Notes: Mean months from asylum application filing to personal interview (*Anhörung*), by quarter. Lines show quarterly averages for the overall caseload, Afghanistan, Iraq, and Syria. The shaded region marks 2016–2018. Gaps indicate quarters not covered by the parliamentary inquiry source. Source: Federal parliamentary inquiry data on immigration office processing times, 2013–2018.

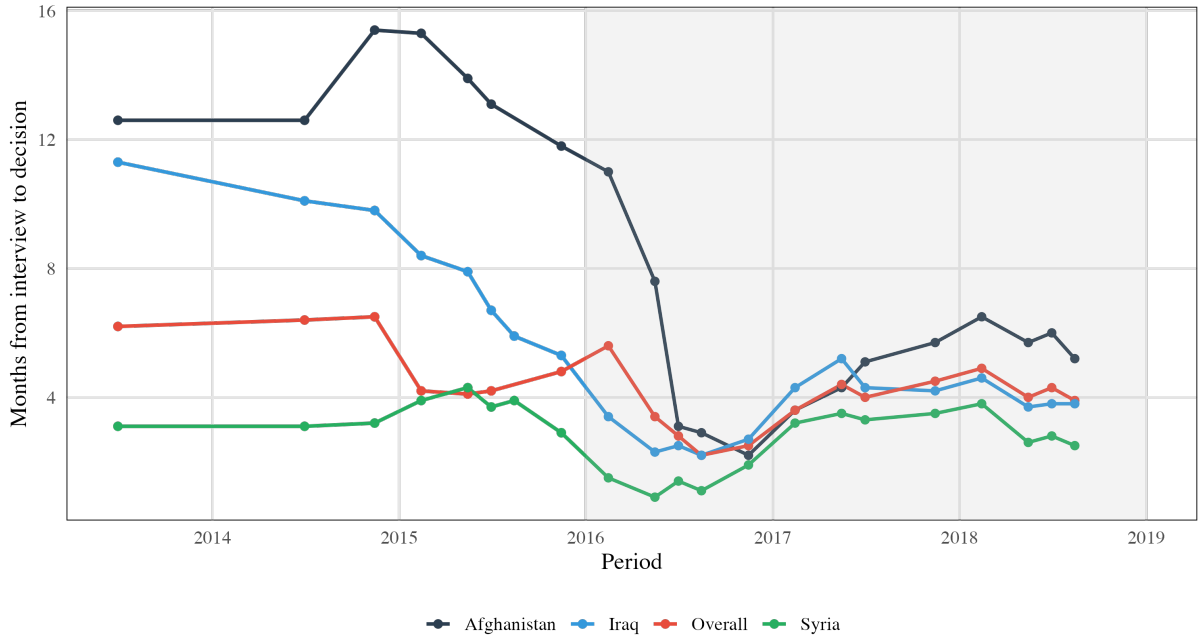


Figure A.4: Duration from Interview to Decision

Notes: Mean months from personal interview (*Anhörung*) to final branch-office decision, by quarter. Lines show quarterly averages for the overall caseload, Afghanistan, Iraq, and Syria. The shaded region marks 2016–2018. Gaps indicate quarters not covered by the parliamentary inquiry source. Source: Federal parliamentary inquiry data on immigration office processing times, 2013–2018.

B Identification: Supporting Evidence

This appendix reports the supporting evidence for the threats discussed in Section 7.

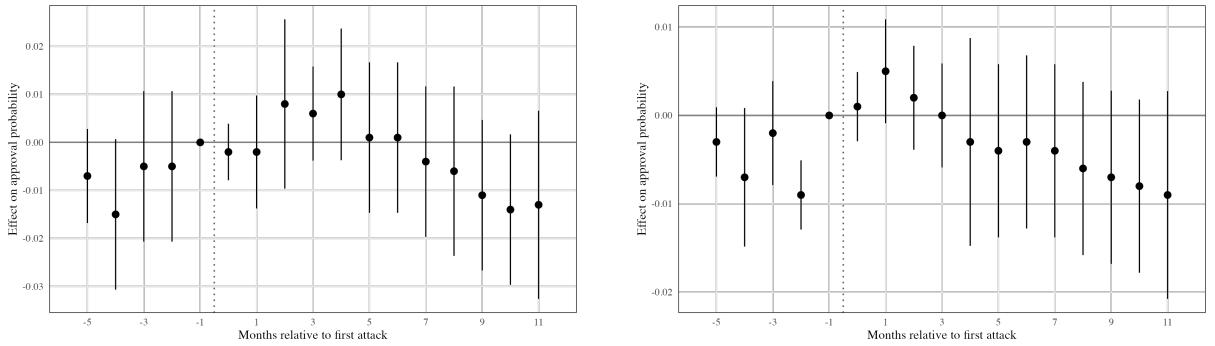
Table B.1: Balance: treated vs. control counties

	Treated	Control	Diff.	p
Panel A: All counties				
Register attrition ($\ln N^{2023}/N^{2021}$)	-0.070	-0.029	-0.041	0.261
	(0.022)	(0.029)	(0.036)	
Naturalizations 2020–2023 (% of foreign pop.)	5.68	6.08	-0.40	0.120
	(0.14)	(0.21)	(0.25)	
N	227	140		
Panel B: Immigration office counties				
Register attrition ($\ln N^{2023}/N^{2021}$)	0.046	0.105	-0.059	0.649
	(0.083)	(0.099)	(0.129)	
Naturalizations 2020–2023 (% of foreign pop.)	5.91	5.74	0.17	0.820
	(0.35)	(0.63)	(0.72)	
N	33	16		

Notes: Treated counties experienced at least one arson attack within 25 km. Control counties are never-treated. Register attrition defined as $\ln(N_c^{2023}/N_c^{2021})$ where N_c^t is the total number of protection-title holders in county c across the 2015–2018 recognition cohorts in the CRF extract of year t. Naturalizations are cumulative 2020–2023 counts as a percentage of the county's 2020 foreign population (Destatis Einbürgerungsstatistik). Standard errors of the mean in parentheses. Immigration office counties are those hosting a branch office of the Federal Office for Migration and Refugees. Sample restricted to counties observed in both datasets.

B.1 Balance Tests

The balance test in Figure B.1 checks whether applicant composition, as summarized by predicted approval rates, shifts systematically around the timing of a first nearby arson attack. Predicted approval rates are computed from cell means (nationality × calendar month × gender × family status × minor status) using either pre-treatment periods or the never-treated sample, which summarize an applicant's expected approval probability based on observable characteristics alone. I then regress each predicted rate on the same event-study specification used for the main outcome (Equation 6), restricting to the first observation per application. If treatment status is uncorrelated with applicant composition, the event-time coefficients should be statistically indistinguishable from zero throughout the event window. Significant pre- or post-treatment movements in predicted approval rates would indicate compositional change that the calendar month × duration × nationality fixed effects in the main specification are absorbing. Both variants, using pre-treatment and never-treated cell means, show no evidence of compositional change.



(a) Pre-treatment cell means **(b) Never-treated cell means**

Figure B.1: Balance Tests: Predicted Approval Rates around Treatment

Notes: Event-study coefficients from regressions of predicted approval rates on event-time dummies (stacking estimator, Equation 6), relative to the month before treatment ($k = -1$). Predicted rates are computed from cell means (nationality × calendar month × gender × family status × minor status) using pre-treatment periods (a) or the never-treated sample (b). Sample restricted to the first observation per application. All specifications include branch office × sub-experiment, residence county × sub-experiment, and calendar month × duration × nationality × sub-experiment fixed effects. Standard errors clustered at the branch office level. Vertical bars show 95% confidence intervals. Source: AZR Research Dataset 2023; parliamentary interpellations (arson events).

C Additional Results

C.1 Heterogeneous Effects

Table C.1 reports subgroup estimates; Section 8.4 discusses them together with pooled interaction tests. Geographically, the estimate is identified from West Germany; a separate East Germany split is uninformative because nearly all eastern offices experienced their first nearby attack early in the sample window, leaving a single never-treated eastern office (Jena-Hermsdorf). Applicants from Muslim-majority origin countries show a larger point estimate than other applicants, but the estimate falls short of conventional significance. The nationality-group rows split the sample into Syrian, Eritrean, and Iraqi applicants and all other nationalities. The estimate for Syrian, Eritrean, and Iraqi applicants is too imprecise to be informative, with a standard error roughly five times that of the main estimate.

C.2 Robustness

This subsection reports the robustness checks discussed in Section 6.1. Table C.2 varies the fixed-effect structure of the main specification. Table C.3 shortens the maximum observation window after application from 12 to 9, 6, and 3 months; these specifications pool the never-treated and not-yet-treated comparison groups.

Table C.1: Heterogeneous effects: Post-period DiD summary

Subgroup	Post × Treated	SE	N	Persons
Geography				
West Germany	-0.008***	(0.003)	2,444,981	82,073
Political context				
Low AfD vote share (2013)	-0.010**	(0.004)	2,458,082	63,171
High AfD vote share (2013)	-0.003	(0.003)	2,457,838	66,083
Attack severity				
Aggravated arson	-0.008**	(0.003)	2,515,796	71,521
Simple arson	-0.004	(0.004)	2,400,124	57,733
Demographics				
Male	-0.008***	(0.003)	2,547,045	76,217
Female	-0.003	(0.003)	2,368,875	53,037
Muslim-majority origin	-0.008	(0.005)	2,438,292	65,268
Other origin	0.000	(0.001)	2,477,628	63,986
Nationality group				
Syria, Eritrea, Iraq	-0.006	(0.014)	2,324,222	49,986
Other nationalities	-0.001	(0.001)	2,591,698	79,268

Notes: Summary of post-period difference-in-differences estimates across heterogeneity dimensions. Dependent variable: binary indicator equal to one if the applicant receives any form of protection in a given month. Each row corresponds to a subgroup estimated from a separate stacking regression with a single post-treatment indicator (never-treated comparison). Splits classify observations by the indicated attribute while retaining the full never-treated comparison group; the West Germany row instead restricts the sample to western states. Pooled interaction tests for the AfD and severity dimensions are reported in Section 8.4. The nationality-group rows compare Syrian, Eritrean, and Iraqi applicants with all other nationalities; written-procedure cases are excluded from all rows. N denotes person-months in the stacked panel; Persons denotes unique applicants. All specifications include branch office × sub-experiment, residence county × sub-experiment, and calendar month × duration × nationality × sub-experiment fixed effects, and demographic controls. Standard errors clustered at the branch office level. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table C.2: Robustness: Fixed-Effect Specifications

	(1)	(2)	(3)	(4)	(5)
Post × Treated	-0.005**	-0.005*	-0.006**	-0.009**	-0.009**
	(0.002)	(0.003)	(0.003)	(0.004)	(0.004)
Mean dep. var.	0.026	0.026	0.026	0.026	0.026
Observations	2,682,401	2,682,401	2,682,401	2,682,401	2,682,401
Persons	95,320	95,320	95,320	95,320	95,320
Office × sub-exp.	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes	Yes
Res. county × sub-exp.	Yes	Yes	Yes		
Duration × sub-exp.	Yes	Yes			
Month × sub-exp.	Yes				
Nationality × sub-exp.	Yes				
Month × nat. × sub-exp.		Yes			
Month × dur. × nat. × sub-exp.			Yes	Yes	Yes
Res. county × month × sub-exp.				Yes	Yes
Office state × month × sub-exp.					Yes

Notes: Each column reports the collapsed post-treatment coefficient from the stacking estimator (Equation 5) under a different fixed-effect structure, indicated in the lower panel. Dependent variable: any protection (never-treated comparison). Column (3) closely reproduces the main specification in Table 2; it differs only in the identifier used for the residence-county × sub-experiment fixed effect, and the estimate is identical after rounding. All specifications include demographic controls (gender, birth year, minor status, time since arrival). Standard errors clustered at the branch office level in parentheses. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.

Table C.3: Robustness: Maximum Observation Duration

	(1) 9 months	(2) 6 months	(3) 3 months
Post × Treated	-0.008***	-0.010**	-0.010*
	(0.003)	(0.004)	(0.005)
Mean dep. var.	0.025	0.026	0.024
Observations	2,801,863	2,217,006	1,423,076
Persons	95,938	95,938	95,938

Notes: Each column reports the collapsed post-treatment coefficient from the stacking estimator (Equation 5) restricting the panel to the indicated number of months after application. Dependent variable: any protection. These specifications pool the never-treated and not-yet-treated comparison groups. The pooled comparison group yields 95,938 applicants, compared with 95,320 in the preferred never-treated regression. Observations count stacked person-month records. All specifications include branch office × sub-experiment, residence county × sub-experiment, and calendar month × duration × nationality × sub-experiment fixed effects, as well as demographic controls. Standard errors clustered at the branch office level in parentheses. * $p < 0.10$, ** $p < 0.05$, *** $p < 0.01$.